AFRICAN DEVELOPMENT BANK GROUP

IDEV
Independent Development Evaluation
Évaluation indépendante du développement

Liberia: Evaluation of the African Development Bank's Country Strategy and Program (2013–2023)

Summary Report

September 2024

Acknowledgments

Task manager	Boubacar Ly, Principal Evaluation Officer
Team member	Bilal Bagayoko, Evaluation Officer
Consultant	ADE consulting & Advisory Services: Hubert Cathala and Edward Rackley, team leaders
Internal peer reviewers	Andrew Ajuang Anguko, Chief Quality and Methods Advisor; Mohammed Jalaludeen Issahaq, Principal Evaluation Officer
External peer reviewer	Foday Turay, Independent Consultant
Internal Bank reference group	Riadh Ben Messaoud, Lead Coordinator (RDTS); Sohir Debbiche, Principal Results Officer (SNDR.1); Ihcen Naceur, Principal Results Officer (SNDR.1), Emmanuel Maniragaba, Regional Power System Officer (PESD.2/COCM), Ebrima Bah, Power Engineer (PESD.3/COLR), Prince D. Tambah, Transport Engineer (COLR); Alex Yeaney, Senior Fragility & Resilience Officer (RDTS/RDGW); Yusuf B. Foday, Senior Country Economist (ECCE.1/COLR)
Knowledge management and communications officers	Christine Bukania, Principal Knowledge Management Officer; Aminata Kouma, Evaluation Knowledge Assistant; Kate Stoney, Senior Communications Officer
Other assistance/ contributions provided by	Parfait Yao Kouassi, Team Assistant; Ruby Esi Adzobu-Agyare, Team Assistant
Special thanks to	Liberia Country Office (COLR) team members and other Bank staff for their contributions and cooperation during the evaluation; Government of Sierra Leone, development partners, private sector clients for sharing their experiences with African Development Bank (AfDB) assistance
Division manager	Rufael Fassil
Evaluator-general	Karen Rot-Munstermann

Table of contents

Tables and Figures

Tables

Figures

Acronyms and Abbreviations

ADF	African Development Fund
AfDB	African Development Bank Group
AFT	Agenda for Transformation
ASM	Artisanal small-scale mining
BTOR	Back-to-Office Report
CLSG	Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Guinea
CODE	Committee on Operations and Development Effectiveness
COLR	Liberia Country Office
CPPR	Country Portfolio Performance Review
CSP	Country Strategy Paper
CSPE	Country Strategy and Program Evaluation
DP	Development Partner
E&S	Environmental and Social
EU	European Union
EVD	Ebola Viral Disease
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization
FTHRP	Fishtown to Harper Road Project
GAFSP	Global Agriculture and Food Security Program
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GoL	Government of Liberia
HDI	Human Development Index
IDEV	Independent Development Evaluation
IFMIS	Integrated Financial Management Information System
IMF	International Monetary Fund
IPFM RP	Integrated Public Financial Management Reform Project
IPR	Implementation Progress Report
ISP	Institutional Support Program
JAS	Joint Assistance Strategy
LAAC	Liberian Anti-Corruption Commission
LEC	Liberia Electricity Corporation
LEEAP	Liberia Energy Efficiency and Access Project
LERP	Liberia Economic Recovery Plan
LoC	Line of Credit
LRA	Liberian Revenue Authority
MACs	Ministries Agencies and Commissions
M&E	Monitoring and Evaluation
MPW	Ministry of Public Works
MRU	Mano River Union
MTR	Mid-Term Review
NDP	National Development Plan
NSO	Non-Sovereign Operation
PAPD	Pro-Poor Agenda for Prosperity and Development
PBO	Program Based Operation
PCR	Project Completion Report
PFM	Public Finance Management
PIU	Project Implementation Unit
PMU	Project Management Unit
PPP	Public-Private Partnership
PRA	Project Results Assessment
PSD	Private Sector Development
REEL	Renewable Energy for Electrification
RAP	Resettlement Action Plan
SADFONS	Smallholder Agriculture Development Food and Nutrition Security
SAP	Systems Application and Products
SREP	Scaling Up Renewable Energy Program
SRF	Special Relief Fund
TSF	Transition Support Facility
TYS	Ten-Year Strategy
UA	Unit of Account
UN	United Nations
UNDP	UN Development Programme
UNHCR	UN High Commissioner for Refugees
WAPP	West African Power Pool
WFP	World Food Program
WHO	World Health Organization
YEEP	Youth Entrepreneurship and Employment Program

Executive Summary

Introduction

This report summarizes the key findings, lessons, and recommendations of an evaluation of the African Development Bank Group's (AfDB or "the Bank") strategies and programs in Liberia from 2013 to 2023. Over the period, the Bank formulated two Country Strategy Papers (CSPs): CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018) and CSP 2019-2024 (extended to 2025). Both CSPs focused on similar objectives (pillars), namely: (i) inclusive economic growth and diversification; and (ii) governance and private sector development (PSD).

Under these two CSP cycles, the Bank approved 37 operations amounting to Units of Account (UA) 388.9 million, distributed among four key sectors: transport, energy, agriculture, and multisector. Eighty-five percent of the Bank's support to Liberia (UA 329 million) was channeled through the African Development Fund (ADF) window, of which UA 88.7 million was financed through the Transition Support Facility (TSF). Two Non-Sovereign Operations (NSOs) were approved (but not implemented) during the period under review.

Purpose and scope of the evaluation

The primary purpose of this evaluation is to inform the implementation of the remainder of the ongoing (extended) CSP and the design and implementation of the next strategy cycle (2026-2030) for enhanced development effectiveness. The evaluation focuses on both accountability and learning and seeks to: (i) assess the Bank's contribution to development results in Liberia; (ii) identify operational factors that have enabled and/or hindered successful implementation and achievement of expected results; and (iii) distill lessons and recommendations for future programs.

The evaluation framework is articulated around five evaluation questions that guided data collection:

1. **Relevance:** To what extent were the objectives and design of the two consecutive Liberia CSPs relevant to the country's and beneficiaries' needs and priorities, adapted to the country context, aligned with the Bank's strategic frameworks, and remained relevant as circumstances changed?
2. **Coherence**: To what extent were aspects or dimensions of the Liberia CSPs able to build synergies and linkages with other Bank interventions and to complement, harmonize, and coordinate with the interventions of other development partners operating in Liberia?
3. **Effectiveness**: To what extent were the Liberia CSPs effective in achieving expected development results (outputs and outcomes)?
4. **Sustainability**: Have CSPs' achievements continued and/or are likely to be sustained after conclusion of the assistance provided?
5. **Efficiency**: How efficient were the performances of the Bank and the Borrower (Government of Liberia) as development partners in designing, implementing, and managing the Liberia country strategy and operations for results?

Methodology

The evaluation used a theory-based approach to assess the extent to which the Bank's interventions, including Sovereign and NSOs, lending and non-lending activities, under each pillar of its two CSPs, designed and delivered a relevant response to Liberia's development challenges. The evaluation applied the standard international evaluation criteria of relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. It used a four-point scale[1] to rate performance against these criteria (Annex 2). It used four methods to gather data: (i) desk reviews of key documents; (ii) portfolio review; (iii) interviews and focus group discussions; and (iv) Project Results Assessments (PRAs).

The evaluation encountered some limitations and challenges, which included: (i) limited availability of interviewees; (ii) incomplete institutional memory; (iii) limited availability of documents; (iv) the status of operations in the portfolio covered; and (v) limited access to project sites. The evaluation team managed to overcome these limitations through triangulation of information from multiple sources, applying the evaluation criteria, and addressing the evaluation questions to a significant extent.

Key evaluation findings

Relevance

Alignment. The evaluation found that the Bank's support responded to the immediate needs of the Government of Liberia (GoL) and its population as defined in the two successive national

[1] The ratings are: 1 - Unsatisfactory, 2 - Partly Unsatisfactory, 3 - Satisfactory, and 4 - Highly Satisfactory.

development agendas. For instance, the Bank's objective of addressing governance issues through strengthening Public Finance Management (PFM), procurement and auditing, expanding resource mobilization, and increasing accountability and transparency, was found to be highly relevant to the needs and priorities expressed by the GoL's 2012-2017 Agenda for Transformation and Pro-Poor Agenda for Prosperity and Development (2018-2023). The evaluation also found both Bank CSPs in Liberia aligned with the AfDB's institutional strategies designed to support Africa's economic development and social progress by promoting infrastructure and private sector development, as well as regional integration. The evaluation equally found that the two CSPs showed relevance in responding to the Bank's 2014-2019 *Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa* in several ways.

Quality of design. The evaluation found that the Bank's assistance across both CSPs was informed by the fragility context and was designed to address the main drivers of fragility in specific sectors. The evaluation also found that the Bank demonstrated flexibility in adapting to changing circumstances, with the rapid mobilization of COVID-19 and Ebola Budget Support contributing to macro fiscal stability. In addition, while recognizing that achieving the country's development objectives will require long-term measures, the Bank identified and sustained critical infrastructure development and governance across both CSPs. However, the evaluation found the links between the CSPs' inputs and outcomes to be based on hypotheses and assumptions that were not systematically contextualized. The catalytic interaction of these inputs to achieve the desired cumulative outcomes was not well planned, tracked or analyzed against a causal Theory of Change.

Overall, the relevance of the Bank's strategies and programs is rated as satisfactory, while noting some important shortcomings.

Coherence

Internal coherence. The evaluation found that the Bank's portfolio showed good coordination and synergies between sectors. However, it also identified a weakness with respect to the Bank's commitment to developing Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) in the energy sector.

External coherence. The evaluation found evidence of strong coordination with other development partners at sector level, with increased regularity of interactions to support the country's response to the Ebola crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. However, external coherence between the multiple actors could have benefited from a stronger coordination at sector level by the Liberian authorities.

Overall, the coherence of the Bank's support to Liberia is rated as satisfactory.

Effectiveness

Delivery of development results (outputs and outcomes). A review of the two CSPs (2013-2023) revealed a partly unsatisfactory performance, as only 40 percent of the expected outputs and 27 percent of the expected outcomes were met at the time of the evaluation. The evaluation highlighted that while some expected outputs and outcomes were achieved, there were only a few cases of full achievement, and many gaps remained. However, a number of additional outputs (47 percent) and outcomes (41 percent) are likely to be achieved in the short or medium term. Given the transition country status of Liberia, the remaining outcomes may take time to materialize.

Output delivery. The evaluation rated the achievement of outputs by Bank CSPs in Liberia as partly unsatisfactory. Expected outputs were achieved with many gaps, and in only a few cases were outputs fully achieved. The overall output execution ratio for Bank support to Liberia is 40 percent (12 out of 30 outputs). However, an additional 14 outputs, representing a ratio of 47 percent, are likely to be achieved in the near term. With most projects in the energy and transport sectors still ongoing, only three out of 15 of the outputs under pillar 1 "inclusive economic growth and diversification" are fully achieved. Under this pillar, the Bank focused on energy and road infrastructure, with an emphasis on reducing exclusion. With respect to energy, the Bank supported transformative infrastructure investments in the sector under its CSP 2013-2017 to address the severe power shortage and the high cost of electricity in Liberia. Most of the projects are still ongoing but some, such as the Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Guinea (CSLG) (transmission line component), approved in 2013, and the Liberia Energy Efficiency and Access Project (LEEAP), approved in 2016, have already delivered results. Regarding the transport sector, road projects were still ongoing, and the completed roads were not yet linked to the national road/transport network. During the evaluation team's visit, 220 out of the planned 243 kilometers (90 percent) had been completed and were open for use. In the agriculture sector, the Bank supported the development of rural roads and transportation networks to improve the accessibility of rural areas and reduce the costs of transporting goods. However, the evaluation found that poor communication networks and unreliable information make it difficult for smallholder farmers to access both input and output markets.

Similarly, only nine out of 15 of project outputs under pillar 2 “economic governance and PSD” are fully achieved. In the governance sector, outputs were most often partially achieved, such as in the case of the Economic Governance and Competitiveness Support Program (EGCSP II, 2018-2020). Through the first CSP 2013-2017, three of the five outputs (60 percent) expected from the Economic Governance Budget Support and the Institutional Support Project (ISP) were fully met. In agro-forestry, where the Bank provided value addition support to SMEs, outputs delivered included capacity building in carpentry, establishment of carpentry associations, and the procurement of wood-refining and carpentry machines. While the training provided included elements of entrepreneurship and marketing, no real-time coaching or mentoring was offered to help carpenters’ associations overcome their specific challenges. As a result, carpentry association members in the SME Wood Processing project expressed frustration with the minimal sales of their finished products.

Outcome delivery. The evaluation rated the achievement of outcomes by Bank CSPs in Liberia as partly unsatisfactory. Very few targeted outcomes were achieved, with significant gaps remaining. The overall outcome execution ratio for Bank support to Liberia is 27 percent (six out of 22 outcomes assessed). However, an additional nine outcomes are likely to be achieved.

With most projects in the energy and transport sectors still ongoing, only three of the 11 outcomes under pillar 1, “inclusive economic growth and diversification” have been fully achieved. The evaluation found that the Bank’s interventions in the energy sector partially met their objectives, as they contributed to increasing access to electricity (though not to the expected level) and reducing the cost of electricity. However, realizing all the energy sector outcomes will take time. In the transport sector, outcome indicators collected by the evaluation suggest that the Bank’s support in the road sub-sector has contributed to improved road safety and reduced travel time. Other sector objectives such as reducing the average Vehicle Operating Cost (VOC), better access to rural areas, and improved road governance and maintenance have not yet fully materialized. Additionally, the evaluation found that in the agro-forestry sector, SME beneficiaries did not experience increased sales or better living conditions. However, support for the agriculture sector has positively impacted the trade and commerce environment through increased productivity.

Under pillar 2 “economic governance and PSD”, only three out of 13 outcomes have been fully achieved. The evaluation found that the Bank’s multisector operations contributed to the consolidation of financial control and oversight of government finances, and a stronger PFM system (fiscal discipline, strategic allocation of resources, and efficient public service delivery). However, efforts to improve the procurement process yielded few positive results. In addition, the evaluation found that private sector operations have been slow to materialize and that indirect support to SMEs and agribusiness has produced mixed results. This is mainly due to the challenging business environment in the country, coupled with uncertainties arising during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Overall, the evaluation rated the effectiveness of the Bank’s strategies and programs as partly unsatisfactory.

Knowledge and policy advice

The Bank’s contribution to knowledge creation and policy dialogue was deemed limited. The technical and strategic policy dialogue with Liberian authorities to ensure well-tailored macroeconomic policies were mainly driven by the International Monetary Fund (IMF). The EGCSP II provided an opportunity for the Bank to engage in policy dialogue with the new Government on various policy issues. The evaluation also found that the Bank pursued policy dialogue with the GoL to implement recommendations of the domestic revenue mobilization strategy, leading to key reforms. In addition, the creation of Special Economic Zones (SEZ) was strongly supported by the Bank mainly through reform incentives.

Fragility and resilience

The evaluation found that, overall, the Bank adequately applied the fragility lens to its successive strategies. For example, the Bank CSPs involved complementary strategies and operations designed to address forms of state weakness, increase national integration and foster inclusive economic growth. The Bank also conducted two major fragility assessments, one at the beginning of each CSP cycle, to ensure the integration of its fragility lens across all interventions. As a result of these assessments, the CSP 2019-2023 emphasized that support to Liberia requires a medium to long-term approach to continued investment to consolidate the work done under the previous cycle. The AfDB also participated closely in policy dialogue, developing partnerships and advocacy around urgent public health issues that threatened to overwhelm government capacity during the Ebola and COVID-19 pandemics. Furthermore, the evaluation found that across its two successive CSPs, the AfDB paid particular attention to horizontal inequalities, social exclusion and gender inequalities as drivers of fragility in design and implementation.

Gender

Liberia has made progress on addressing gender equality, but considerable gaps remain. At strategic level, the AfDB recognizes that gender inequality is a significant obstacle to Africa's development and is committed to promoting gender equality and women's empowerment. At operational level, the Bank's 2020 Country Resilience Fragility Assessment (CRFA) for Liberia included gender inequalities as a key driver for fragility, and there is evidence of efforts to address this through some operations in the transport, agriculture, and social sectors, for example the Mano River Union Phase 1 (MRU-1) and Phase 2 (MRU-2) transport projects; the Smallholder Agricultural Productivity Enhancement and Commercialization (SAPEC) project; and the Youth Entrepreneurship and Employment Project (YEEP). However, the evaluation found that apart from regular Bank reporting (Implementation Progress Reports and the occasional Mid-Term Review), there are no additional performance management strategies or monitoring and evaluation (M&E) systems for cross-cutting issues such as gender equity, environment and climate change, and inclusive growth.

Environment and climate change

The GoL, through its Resilience and Adaptation agenda, recognizes the country's vulnerability to climate change and external shocks. The evaluation found that the Bank ensured that environmental and social safeguards (E&S) were identified through dedicated studies in advance of its operations. For instance, the Scaling Up Renewable Energy Program in Low Income Countries (SREP) program for 2015 experienced a slow start-up period because the recruitment of consultants and completion of the Environmental and Social Impact Assessment only started in 2017. In addition, the Bank supported the GoL efforts to promote environmental sustainability through some targeted operations. However, some practical challenges remain regarding the implementation of E&S measures and the M&E efforts to promote environmental sustainability. The E&S department is reportedly planning to address these challenges through capacity building sessions for project staff, various agencies, and institutions.

Sustainability

In terms of the **technical soundness** of the Bank's operations throughout the two strategic cycles, the evaluation found some generally positive results, and rated it satisfactory. However, weak technical soundness in some projects was found to represent a significant risk to results achieved or likely to be achieved at pillar level. For instance, in transport, field visits revealed the poor quality of some intersections with feeder roads. For **financial sustainability**, the evaluation found the essential requirements for ensuring the financial sustainability of interventions in key sectors like energy and transport to be partly unsatisfactory across all CSP pillars and sectors, except for governance projects. This was primarily due to insufficient resources for the operation and maintenance of services. The long-term **environmental and social sustainability** of the Bank's investments under the two CSPs is considered generally satisfactory. However, the evaluation identified some concerns with the agro-forestry project supporting SMEs in wood processing. Specifically, the project lacked a reforestation component and relied solely on raw timber supplies. Additionally, no formal environmental sustainability measures were established for the wood processing SMEs. Finally, the evaluation found that despite the Bank's efforts to enhance **institutional sustainability and ownership**, this remains limited, and the sustainability in the medium to long-term is not guaranteed.

Overall, sustainability of the Bank's support to Liberia's development was rated partly unsatisfactory, with significant weaknesses in institutional capacity and measures for ensuring financial sustainability and ownership of Bank interventions in the medium to long-term.

Efficiency

Timeliness. Most of the Bank's interventions were found to suffer from significant start-up and implementation delays. Start-up delays characterized almost the entire AfDB portfolio in Liberia, especially in the energy, transport and agricultural sectors. In addition, most operations suffered significant implementation delays, to the extent that their original closing dates had to be extended at least once, with their disbursement ratios lagging relative to their age.

Return on investment. Despite generally sound public management practices, the evaluation could not compile a comprehensive picture of the returns on public investment in Liberia. However, weak project results point to negative returns on investments.

Partnerships and leverage. The evaluation evidence showed that the Bank has built strong partnerships with other development partners (DPs) at both sector and project levels. The Bank also mobilized resources (nearly UA 175 million) from other DPs and trust funds or initiatives at the global and regional levels.

Managing for development results. The evaluation found that project and CSP results measurement reporting systems and processes were adequately designed but inadequately operationalized and utilized. Furthermore, support for national and AfDB M&E capacity and management was limited.

On the balance, the efficiency of the AfDB support to Liberia was found to be partly unsatisfactory.

Lessons

The following are the key lessons from this evaluation:

- Adaptation and flexibility of programs are crucial for post-crisis recovery in transition environments.
- A holistic approach is required to systematically link improved infrastructure and logistics to positive higher-level outcomes.
- Ex-ante market research and value chain studies can improve project design in production sectors such as agriculture, agro-forestry and SME support.
- Building Government capacity is key for successful planning and implementation in transition countries.

Recommendations

The evaluation proposes the following recommendations for the next Liberia CSP.

1. **Continue Bank support to the transport, energy, and governance sectors to reinforce progress made toward reducing fragility and building resilience**. Priority actions include:
    - Prioritizing support to efforts that enhance the sustainability of results already achieved in key strategic sectors.
    - Integrating mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of benefits of Bank operations at the design stage, for effective implementation.
    - Strengthening internal coherence by building more complementarity and synergies between past and new interventions in key strategic sectors.
    - Building synergies between indirect support to agribusiness and SMEs and (previous and future) operations in the transport and energy sectors.
2. **Improve the design of Bank operations for better achievement of higher-level strategic objectives.** Priority actions include:
    - Better integration of national, local, and sector context analysis into the design of operations in key sectors.
    - Undertaking studies to enhance understanding of structural context-specific factors that hinder the achievement of results.
    - Improving the participation of local stakeholders and beneficiaries in the design of operations targeting specific regions or areas.
    - Anticipating systemic and structural institutional issues inherent to the fragility context of Liberia.
3. **Improve the mainstreaming and monitoring of cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and Bank operations to enhance effectiveness.** Priority actions include:
    - Systematically identifying the structural causes and impacts of the cross-cutting issues relevant to Liberia (fragility, gender inequality, environment and climate change, youth, and regional integration).
    - Specifying objectives at the design stage.
    - Establishing and systematically utilizing M&E mechanisms to monitor progress and address issues when required.
4. **Improve the quality of CSP Results Framework design, measurement, and reporting of results by linking results at the sector and CSP pillar levels.** Priority actions include:

- Improving the reliability, feasibility, and causal relationships in the results chain.
- Establishing a comprehensive set of indicators and corresponding baselines covering the higher-level pillar-related outcomes that are traceable to AfDB actions.
- Ensuring realism and adequacy between the fragility context of Liberia, resource allocation, and targeted results.
- Using existing statistical reporting systems and identifying proxies for the strategic results that the Bank intends to contribute toward.

5. **Maintain strong coordination with other DPs to further enhance development effectiveness.** Priority actions include:
    - Incentivizing government ownership through Technical Assistance in strategic sectors of the Bank's interventions.
    - Undertaking detailed sector-specific stakeholder mapping in key sectors.
    - Developing structured interactions around a clear agenda with a long-term perspective with all concerned ministries, private sector representatives, CSOs, and DPs involved in relevant sectors.

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Rationale for the evaluation

This report provides a summary of Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV)'s assessment of the African Development Bank Group's (AfDB or "the Bank") country strategy and programs in Liberia from 2013 to 2023. The Country Strategy and Program Evaluation (CSPE) for Liberia is part of IDEV's 2022-2024 work program, approved by the Bank's Board of Directors. This evaluation is the first one conducted by IDEV for Liberia.

Over the 2013-2023 period, the Bank formulated two Country Strategy Papers (CSPs): CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018) and CSP 2019-2024 (extended to 2025). Both CSPs focused on similar objectives (CSP pillars): (i) inclusive economic growth and diversification through improved transport and energy infrastructure; and (ii) governance and private sector development (section 2.5.1).

The structure of this summary report is as follows: The introduction section briefly outlines the evaluation's purpose, scope, methodological approach, and limitations. The next section provides the country context, followed by sections that review the country's and the Bank's strategies and portfolio in Liberia. This is followed by three sections presenting the evaluation's findings, evidence of the Bank's contribution to development results, reviews of the Bank's management of interventions, and an assessment of the borrower's performance. The final section includes a set of conclusions, lessons, and forward-looking recommendations.

1.2. Evaluation purpose, questions, and scope

The primary purpose of this CSPE is to provide lessons and recommendations to inform the design and implementation of the next country strategy cycle (2026-2030) for enhanced development effectiveness. The evaluation focuses on both accountability and learning and seeks to achieve the following three key objectives:

- Assess the Bank's contribution to development results in Liberia;
- Identify operational factors that have enabled and/or hindered successful implementation and achievement of expected results; and
- Distill lessons and recommendations for future programs.

The evaluation process is structured around five questions, based on the international evaluation criteria of relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability, with consideration given to enabling and hindering factors. Each evaluation question under each criterion is further detailed into sub-questions (Annex 1).

1. **Relevance:** To what extent were the objectives and design of the two consecutive Liberia CSPs relevant to the country's and beneficiaries' needs and priorities, adapted to the country context, aligned with the Bank' s strategic frameworks, and remained relevant as circumstances changed?
2. **Coherence:** To what extent were aspects or dimensions of the Liberia CSPs able to build synergies and linkages with other Bank interventions and to complement, harmonize, and coordinate with the interventions of other development partners operating in Liberia?
3. **Effectiveness:** To what extent were the Liberia CSPs effective in achieving expected development results (outputs and outcomes)?
4. **Sustainability:** Have CSPs' achievements continued and/or are they likely to be sustained after conclusion of (major) assistance provided?
5. **Efficiency:** How efficient were the performances of the Bank and the Borrower (Government of Liberia) as development partners in designing, implementing, and managing the Liberia CSP and operations for results?

The evaluation assessed all the interventions and financing instruments used by the Bank in Liberia during the 2013-2023 period. This period covers two Bank strategy cycles with a portfolio of 37 approved operations, amounting to Units of Account (UA) 388.9 million, distributed across four key sectors: transport, energy, agriculture, and multisector, please refer to Technical Annex 4 for a comprehensive list of projects that were approved and/or implemented between 2013 and 2023. These operations include investment projects, budget support, lines of credit (LoCs), technical assistance, and institutional capacity building initiatives. Additionally, one operation approved before 2013 and completed during the evaluation period was considered in the analysis of the effectiveness and the sustainability of development results. For more details, refer to Technical Annex 5, which outlines the timeline of projects implemented from 2013 to 2023. The evaluation also assessed the Bank's analytical work, advisory services, policy dialogue, and aid coordination activities.

1.3. Evaluation's approach and methodology

The evaluation used a theory-based approach (Technical Annex 3) to assess the extent to which the Bank designed and delivered a relevant response to Liberia's development challenges during the evaluation period. A theory-based approach makes it possible to collect empirical evidence that shows whether the anticipated changes occurred, why these changes happened (or did not happen), and which factors shaped the pathways through which changes materialized. A brief summary of the evaluation methodology is included in Annex 1. For a more detailed description of the evaluation matrix and methodology, refer to Technical Annexes 1 and 2, respectively.

The evaluation was undertaken through the following steps:

Desk review of key documentation. The evaluation team conducted an extensive document review. Team members consulted the Government's strategies and plans, the Bank's strategies and programs, secondary materials relevant to the country context, other pertinent evaluations, and reports from development partners (DPs).

Portfolio review. The team performed a comprehensive analysis of the Bank's portfolio, gathering information about its nature and composition, distribution across sectors, and implementation status.

Key Informant Interviews and focus group discussions. The evaluation team conducted virtual and in-person interviews and consultations with a wide range of stakeholders within the Bank and in the country. These stakeholders included officials in government ministries and executing agencies, Bank staff, DPs, the private sector, and civil society organizations. The team also interviewed project beneficiaries during project site visits. Technical Annex 6 presents a list of the stakeholders consulted.

Project Results Assessments (PRAs). All projects with a disbursement rate exceeding 75 percent - 17 in total - were analyzed using a PRA grid, derived from the Evaluation Matrix. The PRA primarily relies on qualitative sources of information, such as documentation review, interviews, and focus group discussions conducted with key informants. Interventions with a less than 75 percent disbursement rate (16 projects) were analyzed using a synthetic fiche focusing on the relevance, coherence and sustainability of these projects. This approach was chosen because these projects are not advanced enough to allow for a full assessment of their efficiency, effectiveness, and sustainability.

As mentioned above, the evaluation applied a comprehensive set of internationally recognized evaluation criteria to assess performance. These criteria included relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. The evaluation used a four-point scale[2] (Annex 2) to rate performance against these criteria.

1.4. Evaluation's limitations and mitigation measures

The evaluation encountered some limitations and challenges, which include:

i. **Limited availability of interviewees**: The limited availability of key individuals for interviews did not allow for optimal access to first-hand information and delayed the evaluation process. To address this challenge, the evaluation team carried out a series of remote interviews and relied on desk reviews to analyze some projects and bridge information gaps.

[2] The ratings are 1 – Unsatisfactory, 2 – Partly unsatisfactory, 3 – Satisfactory, and 4 – Highly satisfactory.

ii. **Incomplete institutional memory**: The evaluation faced challenges associated with incomplete institutional memory (both for Bank staff and government actors), particularly regarding the earlier part of the 10-year evaluation period. This was compounded by the lack of a Country Program Officer in the Liberia Country Office (COLR) with a comprehensive grasp of the current portfolio and its early operations since 2012. To address this, the evaluation team tried as much as possible to identify and interview stakeholders involved in the initial stages of projects assessed.

iii. **Limited document availability**: The availability of documents posed another constraint during the evaluation process. In some instances, there was a scarcity of relevant project documents such as Implementation Progress Reports (IPRs), audit reports, Back-to-Office Reports (BTORs), and Project Completion Reports (PCRs). The evaluation team relied on interviews with key stakeholders involved in the projects to bridge information gaps.

iv. **The status of the portfolio covered**: The portfolio evaluated included many ongoing and recently approved operations, particularly in the transport and energy sectors. This limited to some extent the ability of the evaluation team to undertake a thorough assessment of some projects, especially in terms of efficiency, effectiveness, and sustainability. The evaluation team relied on key stakeholder interviews to bridge information gaps. In addition, a much lighter format of PRAs (synthetic fiches) was applied to projects with less than 75 percent disbursement rates.

v. **Access to project sites**: Access to project sites was undermined by inadequate transportation and constrained by weather conditions. Since most project sites are only accessible by road, bad roads and weather conditions made visits to these sites impossible. The team has tried to visit as many project sites as possible around Monrovia where accessibility could be ensured. Whenever field visits were not possible, the evaluation team carried out interviews and relied on desk reviews to bridge information gaps.

The evaluation team managed to overcome these limitations by relying on multiple sources of information. The triangulation of information from multiple sources made it possible to formulate robust judgments, apply the evaluation criteria, and address the evaluation questions to a significant extent.

2. COUNTRY CONTEXT AND THE BANK'S STRATEGY

2.1. The political context

Following independence, Liberia experienced significant internal challenges, including ethnic and class tensions that led to periods of unrest and conflict from 1980 to 2003 (NRC, 2003). Liberia has since made progress in its recovery and rebuilding efforts. However, two decades after the end of the conflict, the country continues to face challenges that could impede progress toward socio-economic and political transformation. Some underlying issues remain, but with the support of development partners, Liberia has maintained peace and security, improved governance, rebuilt some basic infrastructure and taken steps forward on key human development indicators. As the country began to stabilize economically and politically, it was hit by the Ebola Viral Disease (EVD)[3] outbreak in 2015, which strained public health institutions. Liberia was still recovering from the effect of the Ebola crisis when the COVID-19 pandemic struck, disproportionately affecting the population. The November 2023 elections marked the second peaceful transfer of power from the ruling party to the opposition, following the first peaceful and democratic transfer that took place in 2018.

2.2. The economic context

Liberia's economic growth has fluctuated over the years, with an average growth rate of about 7.5 percent between 2010 and 2019. Economic growth in the country was particularly impacted by EVD in

[3] The Ebola Viral Disease (EVD) is said to have infected 22,000 people and killing more than 4,000 in Liberia alone.

2016 and the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, resulting in a decline in Gross Domestic Product (GDP) by 1.6 and 3 percent, respectively. GDP rebounded by 5 percent in 2021 due to improved external demand, higher prices for key exports, growth in mining and construction, and the resumption of domestic activity (World Bank, 2023a). Similarly, inflation in Liberia has fluctuated. It increased from 7.3 percent to 9.9 percent between 2010 and 2014 and sharply rose from 7.7 percent to 24.5 percent between 2015 and 2019, peaking in 2017-2018 due to currency speculation. The upward trend of inflation was reversed in 2021 by a steady decrease in food prices (World Bank, 2023b). However, inflation was projected to rise again to 8.1 percent in 2023, primarily due to energy inflation (World Bank, 2023b).

The Liberian economy faces multiple challenges, including the decrease of Official Development Assistance by half, a fiscal deficit due to reduced grants, a widening current account deficit, and a considerable inefficiency in the financial sector. To address these challenges, the Liberian government is implementing a macroeconomic policy focused on sustainable economic growth, lower inflation, and a stable exchange rate. The policy emphasizes macroeconomic stability through fiscal discipline, monetary policy coordination, and structural reforms (World Bank, 2023b).

2.3. The social context

In 2022, Liberia’s population was estimated at 5.3 million. The country faces many challenges, including high levels of poverty and informal employment, and low literacy levels, all of which undermine its economic and human potential. Liberia ranked 178th out of 191 countries on the 2021 Human Development Index (HDI), with an index of 0.481 (UNDP, 2022). According to the latest poverty statistics, 34.2 percent of the population lives below the national poverty line (AfDB, 2023). This situation was further exacerbated by the EVD outbreak and the COVID-19 pandemic. The country still faces significant challenges in education, maternal mortality, gender equality, and access to finance.

The country displays a low literacy rate among youth, with only 55 percent being literate. Women have notably lower literacy rates than men, at 34.1 percent compared to 62.7 percent, respectively. In 2023, the national unemployment rate was estimated at 3.7 percent (AfDB, 2023). However, estimates indicate that 85 percent of the active workforce is employed in the informal sector without access to social security, putting them in a precarious situation. With respect to maternal mortality, the rate (661 maternal deaths for every 100,000 births) is higher than the Sub-Saharan Africa average of 534 (World Bank, 2023b). Liberia has made progress in the area of gender equality, reducing the gap between females and males in terms of participation in the labor market (69.8 percent among women and 79.7 percent among men in 2021). However, more than half of Liberia's population is not connected to a road, with a 2016 Rural Access Index of 41.9 percent (World Bank, 2023c). Liberia also has one of the lowest rates of electricity access in the world, with wide disparities between urban (45.2 percent) and rural (8.4 percent) (World Bank, 2023b).

2.4. National development strategies

Liberia developed two national development strategies between 2013 and 2023. These strategies aimed to foster inclusive growth and wealth creation in the country, in the aftermath of conflicts (Figure 1). In 2012, the Government of Liberia (GoL) unveiled the *Agenda for Transformation: Steps toward Liberia RISING 2030 (2013 – 2018)* (AFT). Anchored in Liberia RISING 2030, a long-term vision for socio-economic transformation and development to achieve Middle Income Country status by 2030, the development framework outlined the country's goals and priorities for economic and social development. The framework hinged upon four main pillars: (i) Peace, Security and Rule of Law; (ii) Infrastructure and Economic Transformation; (iii) Human Development; and (iv) Governance and Public Institutions. Each of these pillars is further broken down into specific sector goals.

Figure 1: Roadmap for Liberia's transformation from post-conflict recovery toward its long-term vision

Source: Liberia's Ministry of Planning and Economic Affairs, 2012

The subsequent *Pro-Poor Agenda for Prosperity and Development (PAPD) 2018-2023* is Liberia's current five-year National Development Plan (NDP). While also aiming at achieving the aspirations of Liberia RISING 2030, this NDP is based on the recognition that despite Liberia's abundant human and natural resources, the country still faces a development deficit primarily because its human capital lacks the knowledge and skills to effectively harness its natural resources. The PAPD was structured around four pillars: (i) Power to the People; (ii) Economy and Jobs; (iii) Sustaining the Peace; and (iv) Governance and Transparency. A 2021 Mid-term Review (MTR) of the strategy led to a recalibration of its objectives. Specifically, pillar 2 of the PAPD (Economy and Jobs) was replaced by the Liberia Economic Recovery Plan (LERP) in response to the macroeconomic effects of the COVID-19 pandemic.

2.5. The Bank's strategies and portfolio

2.5.1. The Bank's country strategies

Over the 2013-2023 period, the Bank formulated two CSPs for Liberia: CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018), and the ongoing CSP 2019-2023 (extended to 2025). Both CSPs address the main drivers of fragility in Liberia through economic governance and infrastructure development, though this focus is more explicitly stated in the latter CSP. While the CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018) aimed at supporting Liberia's transformation toward a stable and inclusive economy, the ongoing CSP 2019-2023 (extended to 2025) focuses on addressing the underlying causes of fragility and increasing the country's resilience (Table 1).

Table 1:Overview of the Bank's strategic priorities in Liberia

CSP period	CSP 2013–2017 (extended to 2018)	CSP 2019–2023 (extended to 2025)
Objective	Support Liberia's transformation toward a stable, inclusive economy.	Address the underlying causes of fragility and increase the country's resilience.
Pillar 1	Promoting inclusive economic growth through transformative infrastructure investments: Focused on addressing the primary infrastructure obstacles to growth by investing in energy and road infrastructure.	Economic diversification through improved transport and energy infrastructure: Aims to improve road and energy infrastructure to drive economic diversification, promote inclusive growth, and deliver better services, particularly in health and education.
Pillar 2	Enhancing governance and the efficient management of resources: Supported sustainable economic governance through addressing weak governance structures, limited institutional capacity, and political instability.	Improving economic governance and enhancing private sector development: Aims to eliminate obstacles for private sector growth, focusing on reforms to create a favorable environment for private sector investment, with a specific emphasis on agriculture to develop value chains, enhance market connections, and diversify crops.

Source: 2013–2018 and 2019–2025 CSPs

CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018), which supported Liberia's transformation toward a stable and inclusive economy, was guided by two pillars: (i) promoting inclusive economic growth through transformative infrastructure investments; and (ii) enhancing governance and the efficient management of resources. The main objective of the first pillar was to foster the private sector, improve agricultural production and market access, create jobs for all genders and ages, and enhance public services and welfare. The second pillar aimed to enhance the policies and capabilities of the government, private sector, and civil society to manage resources in an efficient and transparent manner, maintain macroeconomic stability, and increase accountability through budget support reforms and institutional support. Additionally, the second pillar sought to improve the business environment and reduce barriers to regional and international trade.

CSP 2019-2023 (extended to 2025) addresses the underlying causes of fragility and aims to increase the country's resilience through two pillars: (i) economic diversification through improved transport and energy infrastructure; and (ii) improving economic governance and enhancing private sector development. The former pillar focuses on road construction to improve connectivity, reduce transport costs, and stimulate business. It also supports renewable energy generation and distribution to create a favorable environment for private sector development, which is currently a hindrance. The latter pillar focuses on food security, new income opportunities, and job creation in agriculture, with a particular focus on women and youth. In addition, special emphasis is placed on strengthening resilience to fragility; capacity development; gender and women's empowerment; youth economic empowerment; environment and climate change; and regional integration and trade (especially within the Mano River Union).

2.5.2. The Bank's portfolio in Liberia (2013-2023)

As of December 31, 2023, the Bank's portfolio in Liberia consisted of 37 operations (Annex 5) representing an overall commitment of UA 388.9 million. The bulk of the Bank's support to Liberia was channeled through the **African Development Fund (ADF) window**, which supported the country with UA 329 million mainly in loans. This represented 84.6 percent of the UA 388.9 million approved during the 2013-2023 period. With Liberia classified as a transition country, it is worth noting that support to the country under the ADF's **Transition Support Facility (TSF)** amounted to UA 88.7 million, which represented 27 percent of ADF approvals. With the African Development Bank window providing only UA 0.8 million in funding, the remainder was financed through trust funds such as the European Union (EU) Africa Infrastructure Trust Fund, the Fund for African Private Sector Assistance, the Strategic Climate Fund, the Global Agriculture and Food Security Program (GAFSP), etc. Two Non-Sovereign Operations (NSOs) were approved during the period under review but later canceled. [4] The portfolio includes nine multinational operations (in the transport, finance and governance sectors).

The Bank approved an average of four operations for a total amount of UA 38.8 million annually over the period. There was a significant imbalance between the two CSP cycles. The level of approvals during the 2019-2023 CSP cycle, at UA 121.8 million, represents a 60 percent drop from that of the 2013-2018 CSP cycle, at UA 267.1 million. As of December 2023, 17 projects were ongoing, ten were completed, five were closed, and five operations were approved towards the end of 2022 and throughout 2023 (Table 2). Of the five operations closed, the majority were grants, including three institutional support operations.

Table 2: Operations' status by number and approved amounts

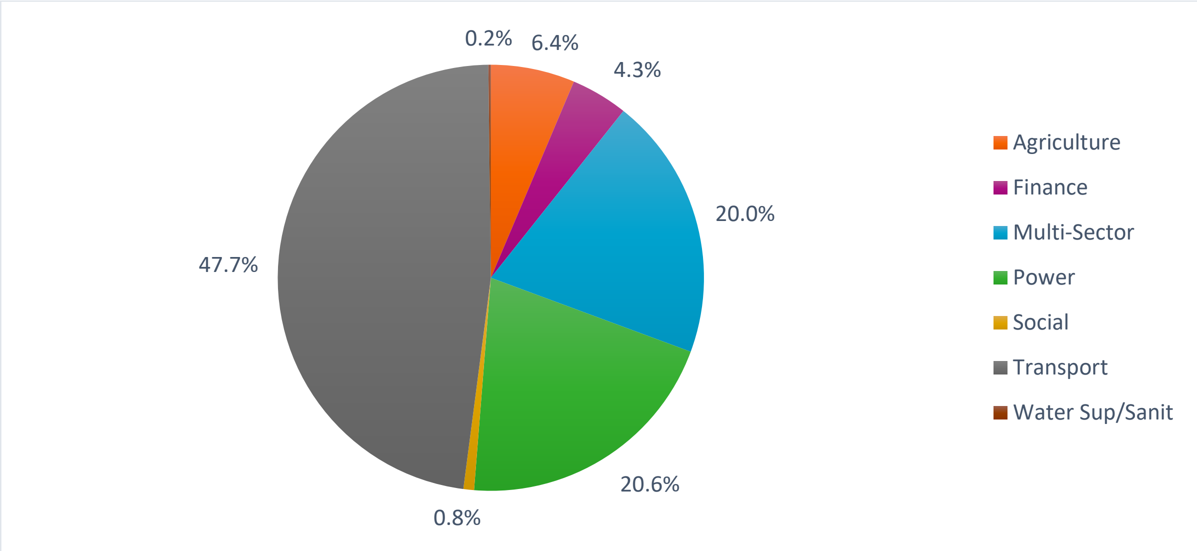
Status	Number of operations	Amount (in millions of UA)	In proportion of total amount
Approved	5	25.3	7%
Closed	5	14.47	4%
Completed	10	51.4	13%
Ongoing	17	297.9	77%
Total	**37**	**388.9**	**100%**

[4] The UA 12 million approved by the Bank in 2013 for the Maryland Palm Oil Plantation was cancelled as the Government did not meet its conditions precedent. Additionally, a UA 12 million trade finance facility was approved by the Bank in 2017 but was later declined by Ecobank.

Source: IDEV, AfDB SAP data

Almost half of the Bank's support to Liberia during the period (in volume terms) went to the transport infrastructure sector, with 47.7 percent of the UA 388.9 million being directed to this area. The transport sector is followed by energy (20.6 percent), governance (20 percent), and agriculture (6.4 percent). Other sectors such as social, water and sanitation, and finance, received significantly less support (Figure 22). In terms of the number of operations approved, the multi-sector tops the list with 13 approved operations. This is followed by agriculture with six, transport with five, and power, social, and finance sectors each with four. The water and sanitation sector received support through one operation.

Figure 2: Sectoral distribution of the Bank's support to Liberia in millions of UA (2013-2023)



Source: IDEV, AfDB SAP data

3. HAS THE BANK MADE THE RIGHT STRATEGIC CHOICES?

3.1. Relevance of the Bank's strategies and programs

Relevance assessed the extent to which the CSPs' objectives and design responded to beneficiaries', global, country, and partner/institution needs, policies, and priorities, and continued to do so even under changed circumstances. It was assessed through: (i) the alignment with beneficiaries' and the GoL's needs and priorities, and Bank strategies; and (ii) the quality of design of the strategy and program.

The relevance of the objectives and design of the AfDB interventions in Liberia over the period 2013-2023 is assessed as satisfactory, while noting some important shortcomings. The Bank's support was found to have responded to the immediate needs of the Government of Liberia and its population as defined in the two successive national development agendas. It was also found to be aligned with the AfDB's institutional policies and strategies. The Bank's assistance across both CSPs was designed to address the main drivers of fragility identified in specific sectors and demonstrated flexibility in adapting to changing circumstances. However, the lack of systematic contextualization of the hypotheses and assumptions in the design *represent an important risk for the achievement of higher-level objectives such as inclusive growth.*

3.1.1. Alignment

The alignment of the Bank's strategy and program in Liberia is rated highly satisfactory.

The evaluation found that both strategic frameworks for Liberia addressed governance issues as a priority. The Bank's approach was highly relevant to explicit governance needs and priorities as expressed by the Government**.** The first CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018) focused on "enhancing governance and the efficient management of resources" with a strong emphasis on promoting inclusive growth, strengthening Public Finance Management (PFM), procurement and auditing, expanding resource mobilization, and increasing transparency. While not directly geared toward governance, the second CSP 2019-2023 emphasized the improvement of accountability and transparency in PFM as well as continued support to revenue mobilization and the reinforcement of key institutions.

The evaluation also found that the Bank's strategies and programs in Liberia were fully consistent with country needs in the governance sector as expressed in key national strategies. They were consistent with the PAPD's (2018-2023) fourth objective of delivering a transparent and accountable governance system and the AFT's (2012-2017) pillar on Economic Transformation and Governance and Public Institutions. In this context, Bank interventions were aligned with the country's PFM Reform Strategy and Action Plans (2011-2016/ 2017-2020) and Domestic Resource Mobilization Strategy (2019-2023), both formulated with the support of the AfDB. These two sector strategies addressed the main issues highlighted by previous assessments[5] conducted in 2016 and provided a useful, common and agreed framework for designing strategies and coordinating donor support.

In addition, the evaluation found that the Bank contributed to addressing the capacity building needs of the country. Capacity building remains a top priority for Liberia given the fragility that characterizes institutions and the need for technical expertise. In the wider context of donor interventions, the Integrated Public Financial Management Reform Project (IPFM RP) Phase I funded through the USD 25 million Multi-Donor Trust Fund was designed to address needs identified by other DPs and aligned with the GoL PFM Reform Strategies. Similarly, through the YEEP under the second CSP 2018-2023, the Bank supported capacity building to improve economic governance, employability, and entrepreneurship among youth as highlighted in the PAPD. Overall, the Bank dedicated nearly UA 11 million to capacity building throughout the period. However, its contribution to capacity building and technical assistance, encompassing both soft and hard investments, remains low vis-à-vis the scale of the needs to reap the potential benefits of a better PFM system.

The evaluation found that the focus of the two CSPs on transport infrastructure was aligned with the needs, policies and priorities of the GoL. The relevance of this focus is demonstrated through direct links to the country's NDPs across two successive administrations (AFT and the PAPD). But the Bank's investments in social infrastructure predate the two CSPs under review. With road rehabilitation central to the institution's earlier Joint Assistance Strategy (JAS) 2008-2011, prepared with the World Bank, a key output was the gravel grading of the Fish Town-Harper Road.[6] This initial engagement with the Ministry of Public Works (MPW) set the stage for the larger investment to pave the same road segment. The two successive CSPs deliberately sought to achieve the wider aims of Liberia's economic recovery, its political stability, and territorial integration through the modernization of the country's road network. This exceptional historical continuity has helped reinforce solid relations with institutional partners, both in the GoL and among DPs, beyond the ten years of this review period.

Similarly, the evaluation found that the Bank's focus on energy infrastructure was aligned with the GoL's needs, policies, and priorities. The first CSP 2013-2017 (extended to 2018) was aligned with Liberia's Scaling up Renewable Energy Program (SREP) investment plan approved in October

---

[5] Reference is made to the 2016 PEFA, the Tax Administration Diagnostic Assessment Tool (TADAT), and the Public Investment Management Assessment (PIMA).

[6] The specific regional target was the isolated and land-locked south-eastern region comprising Maryland, River Gee and Grand Kru counties.

2013. The latter investment plan was prepared by the GoL in close cooperation with the multilateral donors and informed the AFT 2012-2017. The second CSP 2019-2023 is articulated around several areas, with energy and transport infrastructure as key change agents for "economic diversification". This pillar reflects the second pillar of Liberia's own PAPD which targets the development of affordable, clean energy in country.

Furthermore, the evaluation found the AfDB's action in the agricultural sector relevant and aligned with government policy in the sector. Around 70 percent of Liberians depend on agricultural activities for their livelihoods. The Bank's support for cassava and rice production, the primary staple foods, is not unique among donor investments, but it was deemed critical by the Ministry. Through its support to value chains, such as the creation of rice and cassava processing hubs, the Bank aimed to increase farming revenues and productivity. However, with the predominance of small-scale and subsistence agriculture, overall productivity remains low. Additionally, the Bank's support to agro-forestry through SMEs responded to a government-identified need to build technical capacity among rural agriculture training institutes. This support is aligned with the country's strategy to address the lack of technical expertise, which leads to low-quality products, the use of rudimentary hand tools, and low productivity in the artisanal carpentry sector, where over 80 percent of SMEs lack basic power tools.

The evaluation found both Bank CSPs in Liberia aligned with the AfDB's institutional strategies designed to support Africa's economic development and social progress by promoting infrastructure and private sector development, as well as regional integration. The AfDB's support to PFM is instrumental to achieving the High 5s in Liberia. Better financial resource management and enhanced revenue collection are expected to strengthen public service delivery, which ultimately would benefit the Liberian population. The "Economic diversification through improved transport and energy infrastructure" pillar of the second CSP 2018-2023 was closely aligned with pillars of the Bank's High 5s, namely, "Integrate Africa" and "Light up Africa". With key operational priorities in infrastructure (energy and transport) and private sector development (e.g., through economic infrastructure), both CSPs were consistent with the priorities of the Bank's Ten-Year Strategy (TYS) on infrastructure and private sector development, which in turn promotes inclusive growth. The Bank's support to power transmission lines, which helps create a regional market for electricity and fosters infrastructural synergies among Liberia's neighbors, is consistent with the TYS theme of regional economic integration. In addition to initiatives in the energy sector and support to regional trade and economic integration, the AfDB also contributed to the construction of roads connecting Liberia to Sierra Leone and Guinea.

The evaluation equally found that the two CSPs showed relevance in responding to the Bank's strategy to address fragility in several ways. The application of the fragility lens to both CSPs is evident, as they both offer a response to the fragile context characterizing Liberia. Their designs address the main drivers of fragility and are expected to build a more resilient Liberia. In this context, both CSPs are consistent with focus area 1 (strengthen state capacity and support effective institutions) and 2 (promote resilient societies through inclusive and equitable access to employment, basic services and shared benefits from natural resource endowments) of the Bank' s *2014-2019 Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa*.

3.1.2. Quality of design

The quality of the design of the AfDB's strategy and program in Liberia is rated satisfactory.

The evaluation found that the Bank's assistance across both CSPs was informed by the fragility context and was designed to address the main drivers of fragility in specific sectors. The Bank proposed a strategic and appropriate response to fragility in its CSPs and supporting analysis. Indeed, the Bank operations in the context of the first CSP 2013-2017 were designed to invest in continued analysis of the specific forms of Liberian fragility and to mitigate fragility drivers as highlighted in Liberia's 2011 Retrospective Analysis and Fragility Assessment. These include economic exclusion, a fragmented society, limited trust in the state, and continued security risks. For example, the Bank's work on the Fish Town-Harper Road aimed not only to reduce economic fragmentation and increase national integration, but also address local perceptions of economic and political exclusion. The southeast region has the second highest level of inequality after Monrovia, with Fish Town, in River Gee County, having the nation's second highest incidence of poverty. The appropriateness of the Bank's response to fragility in Liberia was also evident in the second CSP 2018-2023 and the Bank's 2020 Country Resilience and Fragility Assessment (CRFA). Both documents concluded that Liberia's fragility indicators were still substantial, and that the country's resilience capacities were low. They found that key drivers of fragility had not significantly evolved from the Bank's CSP 2013-2017 analysis.

The evaluation also found that the Bank demonstrated flexibility in adapting to changing circumstances. The extension of the first CSP 2013-2017 to 2018 contributed to a soft transition and the development of a new strategy. In addition, the rapid mobilization of COVID-19 and Ebola Budget Support contributed to macro fiscal stability. In the transport sector, the Bank granted repeated extensions to several construction projects that started early in 2014 and were scheduled for completion in 2023. With higher international shipping costs and delays to delivery time caused by the COVID-19 pandemic and Russia's invasion of Ukraine[7], the Bank adapted by granting extensions and made efforts to minimize costs in other ways (sending workers home during COVID-19). These adaptations were made possible through regular communication and collaboration between GoL counterparts and Bank staff in affected sectors.

The evaluation also found that the Bank recognized that addressing critical constraints to economic and inclusive growth requires long-term measures. Key constraint areas, namely, infrastructure and governance, were identified and addressed across both CSPs. These constraints were initially targeted by the first CSP 2013-2017. However, with limited progress made during this period, were continued through the second CSP. This continuity was justified in the second CSP by the recognition that these constraints require long-term measures, and by the interruptions caused by the Ebola virus during 2014-2015. While delays in the roads and energy sectors under the first CSP necessitated no-cost extensions into the second CSP, this second CSP also introduced new regional road projects to decrease barriers to regional and international trade.

However, the evaluation found the links between CSP inputs and outcomes to be based on hypotheses and assumptions that were not sufficiently or systematically contextualized. The intervention logic for both CSPs is articulated around several important hypotheses and assumptions. These hypotheses and assumptions highlight the prioritization of infrastructure, regional connectivity, affordable energy, and improved governance as sufficient factors to drive economic growth and greater social inclusion. However, the catalytic interaction of these inputs to achieve the desired cumulative outcomes was not well planned, tracked or analyzed against a causal Theory of Change (ToC). They were instead described as simultaneous channels of activity that would eventually converge to drive economic growth. The successive CSPs also assumed that the main constraints to economic growth were limited infrastructure (transport and energy), governance, and sector-specific productivity, as in agriculture. But economic growth requires other long-term measures, such as improving the business climate, value addition to raw materials (e.g., agricultural produce and timber), light manufacturing, and a skilled labor force to increase trade and reduce Liberia's dependency on imported goods. These weaknesses in the design represent an important risk for the achievement of higher-level objectives such as inclusive growth.

The evaluation also found gaps in the design of the Bank's energy sector approach. The review of the energy sector flagged contextual factors inadequately accounted for in the approaches of the two CSPs. According to the review, gaps were found in the government-led sector-specific policies and institutional reforms upon which the achievement of results such as affordable power and greater domestic energy supply depends. With the high cost of energy production and distribution[8] in Liberia, an analysis of basic market constraints to increasing access to affordable energy should have been incorporated into the design of projects. As a result, despite the gradual expansion of the national power grid toward its 2030 objectives, low income households, particularly in rural areas, still prefer traditional sources of energy.

3.2. Coherence of the Bank's interventions

Coherence assesses the compatibility of an intervention, strategy or program with other interventions in a country, sector or institution. Internal coherence refers to the synergy and linkages among the Bank's interventions. External coherence considers the extent to which Bank interventions were

[7] Language used in the Communiqué issued by the Board of Governors at the AfDB's annual meetings in May 2022; Algeria, China, Egypt, Eswatini, Namibia, Nigeria, and South Africa entered a reservation and proposed "Russia-Ukraine conflict."
[8] Liberia's electricity tariff rate is one of the highest in Africa

consistent with the interventions of other DPs. This criterion is examined through: (i) internal coherence; and (ii) external coherence.

The coherence of the Bank's support to Liberia is rated as satisfactory. The Bank's portfolio showed good coordination and synergies within each sector. However, the evaluation identified a weakness in the internal coherence with respect to the Bank's commitment to developing Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) in the energy sector. The evaluation also identified evidence of strong coordination with other development partners at sector level, with increased regularity of interactions to support the country's response to the Ebola crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. However, external coherence between the multiple actors could have benefited from a stronger coordination at sector level by the Liberian authorities.

3.2.1. Internal coherence

The internal coherence of the Bank's strategy and program in Liberia is rated satisfactory.

The evaluation found that Bank operations in the governance sector were coherent among themselves, with strong complementarities observed. Operations focusing on PFM and overall governance contributed to supporting the implementation of the national PFM reform action plan. In addition, strong complementarities were observed between the Economic Governance and Competitiveness Support Program (EGCSP II, 2018-2020) and the IPFM RP II (2017-2021). The former, a Program Based Operation (PBO), was designed to complement the promotion of good governance and PFM reforms supported through the IPFM RP, and to improve the enabling environment for stimulating private sector investments. The PBO provided additional incentives for pursuing reforms in areas where progress was below expectations, especially in the Integrated Financial Management Information System (IFMIS) roll out, Treasury Single Account (TSA) implementation, payroll control and budget oversight.

Similarly, the evaluation found strong complementarities among operations in the energy sector. The Liberia Renewable Energy for Electrification (REEL) project and the Liberia Energy Efficiency and Access Project (LEEAP) complemented each other. Both projects pursue the same goal, namely the increase of access to electricity and the reduction of electricity tariffs. Under the second CSP, the Bank was also involved in the energy sector, with the preparation of the West African Power Pool (WAPP) between Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone and Guinea (CLSG) Interconnection project to provide electricity to villages along the transmission line.

Internal coherence in the agriculture sector took the form of historical continuity and building on past lessons and experience from the first CSP 2013-2017. The Bank leveraged its prior investments in Liberia through the Agriculture Sector Rehabilitation Project to build capacity using a farmer field schools approach across SAPEC affiliated counties. The Bank also leveraged lessons learned from the earlier phase of the SAPEC project to develop the Smallholder Agriculture Development Food and Nutrition Security (SADFONS) project, currently underway in nine of Liberia's 15 counties, including River Gee, Maryland, Grand Kru and Grand Gedeh - all in the southeast. For quality control, the Bank leveraged the expertise of government line ministries that had worked with previous Bank supported projects and Liberian professionals from the Project Management Unit (PMU) and Project Implementation Unit (PIU) whose capacities were enhanced by the Bank.

The evaluation also found evidence of cross-sectoral complementarity, mutual reinforcement, and synergies. Complementarity and mutual reinforcement are evidenced between the Bank's above-mentioned road construction projects in the southeast and the SAPEC project. Under the Bank-financed Mano River Union (MRU) Roads Project - Phase 1, cross-sectoral produce markets were constructed in Pleebo City and Pedebo, near the border between Liberia and Côte d'Ivoire. Similarly, a clinic and a market were constructed along the 16 km route between Harper Junction and the Cavalla border for towns and villages. The Bank also leveraged synergy between the SAPEC program and its transport sector, by building roadside markets in areas where feeder roads intersected the main artery being renovated in River Gee and Maryland counties. Although hard evidence was unavailable at the time of this evaluation, this approach is expected to multiply the economic benefits from increased road traffic in the southeast region.

The evaluation, however, identified a weakness in the internal coherence with respect to the Bank's commitment to developing PPPs in the energy sector. While the first CSP 2013-2017 identified the need to enhance country partnerships and coordination to support the development and financing of PPPs in the energy sector, little transpired on that front. Additionally, there was no mention of PPPs in the subsequent CSP 2019-2023. This lack of thematic continuity represents a significant weakness in a context where long-term commitments and investments are essential for building synergies.

3.2.2. External coherence

The external coherence of the Bank's strategy and program in Liberia is rated satisfactory.

The Bank was found to be actively involved in the DP sector and sub-sector working groups. In the energy sector, the coordination among DPs benefits from an energy sector working group. The Bank is also an active contributor to the Agriculture Sector Donor Working Group, which is chaired by the Minister of Agriculture of Liberia, and includes the United States Agency for International Development (USAID), the EU, and the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO). The Bank held sectoral dialogues with the CSO/NGO coordination unit and the donor community, including the EU, USAID, and the Swedish Development Agency, to provide updates on the Liberia CSP 2019–2023 and current portfolio achievements. Coordination in the governance sector mainly takes place through various donor coordination groups (a coordination platform and a high-level stakeholder network), particularly in the buildup to presidential elections in October 2023.

The evaluation also revealed strong coordination with other DPs at the project level. In the energy sector, there is evidence of coordination between the Bank's operations and interventions financed by other players such as the World Bank, the EU, and the USAID. While the AfDB operations in the sector focus on increasing access to electricity, the World Bank aims to reduce overall electricity costs by developing renewable energy. The EU projects focus on enhancing the security and regularity of supply. In agro-forestry, the Bank reportedly reviews its development objectives to improve the quality and efficiency of Medium and Small-scale Enterprises to develop new wood-based industries, along with national authorities and stakeholders. But the impact of these reviews had not been documented. In the governance sector, PBOs were designed in coordination with other DPs, including the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the USAID, the EU, the Japan International Cooperation Agency, the Swedish Development Agency (SIDA), and United Nations (UN) agencies.

The evaluation found that consultations and communications with other DPs were enhanced during the Ebola crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. The Bank worked closely with other DPs and the GoL to design the COVID-19 response. The Bank consulted with World Bank, IMF, EU, UN agencies on forms of support provided, instruments used, and geographic areas covered, in order to strengthen donor harmonization and reduce duplication of efforts. For example, the World Bank provided targeted Institutional Support Programs (ISP) financing to contain COVID-19 while providing social safety nets to 10,000 households. The Bank complemented the geographic coverage of this World Bank support with additional safety net funding to reinforce economic resilience for eligible families. The financing needs were estimated by the IMF, who supervised the macro fiscal framework. In addition, anecdotal evidence pointed to an increase in the regularity of sector dialogues during the pandemic.

However, the evaluation identified that external coherence between the multiplicity of actors could have benefited from a stronger coordination at sector level by the Liberian authorities. Overall perceptions are that the GoL is barely involved in sector-specific coordination processes that it should be leading. According to senior Bank staff, this inconsistency is due to high turnover and low technical capacity on the Government side. For instance, synergies are clear between the AfDB, the World Bank, and the EU in the road transport sub-sector, but the onus is on the Ministry of Public Works to demonstrate effective management, coordination, synergy, and complementarity among these multiple, simultaneous interventions across the country. At the local level, good coordination with county authorities informs not only program design but can also guide implementation through unforeseen obstacles, as well.

4. HAS THE BANK ACHIEVED WHAT IT SET OUT TO ACHIEVE?

4.1. Effectiveness

This section discusses the extent to which the intended objectives, outputs and outcomes, as set out in the CSPs and their results frameworks, have been achieved, as well as the AfDB's contribution to the achievement of national development objectives and impacts. In the case of Liberia, the Bank through its interventions aimed to achieve: (i) inclusive economic growth and diversification; and (ii) economic governance and private sector development.

A review of the two CSPs revealed a partly unsatisfactory performance, as only 40 percent of the expected outputs and 27 percent of the expected outcomes were met at the time of the evaluation. The evaluation highlighted that while some expected outputs and outcomes were achieved, only a few cases of full achievement were observed, and many gaps remained. At the same time, a number of additional outputs (47 percent) and outcomes (41 percent) are likely to be achieved in the short or medium term. Given the transition country status of Liberia, the remaining outcomes may take time to materialize.

4.1.1. Delivery of outputs

The evaluation rated the delivery of outputs as partly unsatisfactory (Table 3). Expected outputs were achieved with many gaps, and in only a few cases were outputs fully achieved. The overall output execution ratio for Bank support to Liberia is 40 percent (12 out of 30 outputs). However, an additional 14 outputs, representing a ratio of 47 percent, are likely to be achieved. With most projects in the energy and transport sectors still ongoing, only three out of 15 of the outputs under pillar 1 "inclusive economic growth and diversification" are fully achieved. Similarly, only nine out of 15 of project outputs under pillar 2 "economic governance and PSD" are fully achieved.

Table 3: Output Targets Achieved, 2013-2023

CSPs	Number of targets achieved	Ratio of targets achieved (%)
CSP 2013-2018	7/20	35%
CSP 2019-2023	5/10	50%
Combined Outputs	12/30	40%

Inclusive economic growth and diversification

Under this pillar, the Bank focused on energy and road infrastructure, with an emphasis on reducing exclusion. With respect to energy, the Bank, through its CSP 2013-2017, supported transformative infrastructure investments in the sector to address the severe power shortage and the high cost of electricity in Liberia**.** Most of the projects are still ongoing, but some such as the Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Guinea (CLSG) (2013) (transmission line component) and the LEEAP (2016) have already delivered results. The transmission component is completed. For the LEEAP: (i) construction of 66kV transmission lines and two 66/(33/22)kV substations along the Paynesville – RIA corridor is completed; (ii) construction of the distribution network and customer connections along the Paynesville – RIA corridor is ongoing and expected to be completed by late 2024; and (iii) construction of the distribution network and customer connections along the Pleebo – Fish Town corridor was completed in August 2023; the network is fully operational and has officially been handed over to a private operator by the Liberia Electricity Corporation (LEC). However, the rural electrification component of the CLSG project is still ongoing. The three projects continued through the second CSP 2018-2023 and the expected outputs have been partially delivered. The main constraints to progress have been contractor interruptions during the Ebola and COVID-19 pandemics, as well as limited professional and technical capacity on the government side. In this regard, the evaluation found that the targets for job creation in the energy sector have only been partially met.[9] The Liberia case study conducted as part of IDEV's evaluation of the Bank' s Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa 2014-2019 indicated that nearly 80 percent (120) of the projected 150 permanent jobs have been created in the sector.

Regarding the transport sector, projects in the roads sub-sector were still under execution, and the completed roads were not yet connected to the national road/ transport network. Road construction projects were hampered by multiple external and internal constraints, including the Ebola and COVID-19 outbreaks which sent workers home and suspended construction to respect the quarantine protocols. Of the five transport projects approved, three required further extensions to the end of 2023 and were not yet completed at the time of the evaluation team's visit, although 220 of the 243 km (90 percent) planned had been realized and were open to circulation. Efforts to measure the contribution of the road sub-sector to inclusive growth and economic diversification can however only be achieved after the completion of these projects. It is therefore premature to measure the impact of improved transport infrastructure on economic development and commercial activity.

In the agriculture sector, the Bank supported the development of rural roads and transportation networks to improve the accessibility of rural areas and reduce the costs of transporting goods. However, the evaluation found that poor communication networks and unreliable information make it difficult for smallholder farmers to access input and output markets.[10] Interviews with beneficiaries indicated that the market in Pleebo, Maryland County is unused, as most goods for sale are provided by the Ivoirian side of the border. As the Fish Town to Harper Road Project (FTHRP) road segment was not yet linked to the rest of the national network at the time of this evaluation, the wider agricultural aims of both CSPs to revive and accelerate local trade by increasing access to market opportunities for farmers are not yet evident. For this reason, the evaluation could not establish improvements in the rice and cassava value chains, as demand for local produce in the southeastern regions had not yet increased as anticipated.

Economic governance and private sector development

In governance, outputs were most often partially achieved. Through the first CSP, three of the five outputs (60 percent) expected from the Economic Governance Budget Support and the ISP were fully met. These include: (i) the quarterly production and publication of budget executions with detailed fiscal outturns; (ii) the compliance with procurement law by all Ministries Agencies and Commissions (MACs) and 75 percent of State-Owned Enterprises; and (iii) the consolidation of civil society participation in policy dialogue and monitoring of Government revenues. The target of 80 percent of financial and procurement audits reports produced was partially met.

In private sector development, where the Bank supported the creation of Special Economic Zones (SEZ), the key expected results were: (i) establishment of the SEZ Authority in Liberia by December 2022; (ii) at least USD 450 million of new private sector investment generated by December 2023; and (iii) contribute to reduced unemployment from the then 8.5 percent to at least 5 percent by December 2023. The main achievements so far are: (i) the feasibility study and Master Plan for the Special Agro Industrial Processing Zones (SAIPZ) development completed as of March 2021; and (ii) a Private Sector Investment Climate Study for Liberia completed in June 2021. Both were funded and supported by the Bank, which has also continuously supported reforms through policy dialogue. Evidence of the use of these products and their potential impact on the reform process was however not available at the time of the evaluation.

[9] Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV), 2020. *Evaluation of the AfDB group strategy for addressing fragility and building resilience in Africa 2014-2019: Case Study Report – Liberia*. Available at: https://idev.afdb.org/en/document/evaluation-african-development-bank-groups-strategy-addressing-fragility-and-building

[10] Input markets include resources such as labor, land, and capital to produce products, while output markets exchange goods and services. In other words, the input market supplies the resources needed to make finished products, while the output market buys and uses the finished products.

In agro-forestry, where the Bank provided value addition support to SMEs, outputs delivered include capacity building in carpentry, establishment of carpentry associations, and the procurement of wood-refining and carpentry machines. However, carpentry association members involved in the SME Wood Processing project expressed frustration over minimal sales of their finished products. Despite their training, beneficiaries continue to use manual carpentry tools to fabricate local furniture, which remains unsold. While the training provided included elements of entrepreneurship and marketing, no real-time coaching or mentoring was offered to help carpenters' associations overcome their specific challenges. The carpenters reported that while their training improved their small business management skills, without modern wood finishing equipment (unavailable in Liberia), their furniture would not generate sufficient revenue.

4.1.2. Delivery of outcomes

The evaluation rated the achievement of outcomes by Bank CSPs in Liberia as partly unsatisfactory (Table 4). Very few targeted outcomes were achieved, with significant gaps remaining. The overall outcome execution ratio for Bank support to Liberia is 27 percent (6 out of 22 outcomes assessed). However, an additional nine outcomes are likely to be achieved. With most projects in the energy and transport sectors still ongoing, only three of the 11 outcomes under pillar 1, "inclusive economic growth and diversification" have been fully achieved. Similarly, only three out of 13 outcomes under pillar 2, "economic governance and PSD" have been fully achieved.

Table 4: Outcome execution (2013-2013)

CSPs	Number of targets achieved	Ratio of targets achieved (%)
CSP 2013-2018	4/16	25%
CSP 2019-2023	2/6	33%
Combined Outcomes	6/22	27%

Inclusive economic growth and diversification

Through its energy operations, the Bank's strategies are expected to have a significant impact on inclusive economic growth and diversification through increased access to electricity services and reduced electricity costs, in turn improving citizen welfare. The evaluation found that Bank interventions in the energy sector partially met their objectives as they contributed to increasing access to electricity, though not to the expected level. The final outcomes by the end of 2023 anticipated an increase in the nationwide electricity access rate from 19.2 percent to 45 percent. However, an interview with the Rural and Renewable Energy Agency of Liberia indicated that access rates remain lower – between 25 percent and 30 percent in 2023. Similarly, the evaluation found that the Bank, through its energy sector interventions, contributed to reducing the cost of electricity, but (initially) below expectations. The final outcomes for energy in the first CSP 2013-2017 anticipated a decrease in the cost of electricity from 0.51 USD/kWh to 0.30 USD/kWh by 2017. By the end of the first CSP, the cost of electricity in Liberia had decreased to 0.36 USD/kWh, thus falling short of the target. However, further reductions brought the cost down to 0.25 USD/kWh by December 2021, during the CSP period from 2019 to 2023. Despite these improvements, the rural-urban discrepancy remains high, and Liberia has one of the world's highest electricity tariffs.

Realizing all the energy sector outcomes will take time. With some of the projects nearing completion, it is only now that Liberia will be in a position to objectively measure progress in realizing outcomes. As highlighted above, the objective of increasing electricity access to 45 percent nationwide has not yet fully materialized. In addition, the objective of increasing electricity generation to 200 MW is only partially met, at 124 MW (62 percent).

In the transport sector, outcome indicators collected by the evaluation suggest that Bank support in the road sub-sector has contributed to improved road safety and reduced travel time. An independent 2020 endline survey noted a decrease in motorcycle and car accidents on the Fishtown to Harper Road from 67 in 2015 to 49 in 2020 – a 27 percent drop. In addition, after completion of phase 1 of the FTHRP, the 2020 Fragility Assessment Case Study on Liberia reported that travel time between Harper and surrounding areas had been reduced by 15 percent, which represents some progress but is lower than the projected 33-40 percent. Recent interviews indicated that the travel time has now been reduced by 50 percent.

However, the evaluation revealed that the anticipated rise in motorized traffic as an intermediary outcome of the FTHRP did not occur. The 2020 endline study did not detect the expected increase in motorized traffic along the corridor. This lower than expected level of traffic is attributed to difficult economic conditions in the southeast and therefore fewer goods and services on the move. If accurate, the local traffic level is unlikely to increase if the economy in the region remains under stress. Economic growth is needed in the region, to raise household incomes, and in turn, increase the vehicle traffic on rural and urban roads.

Other sector objectives, such as reduced average Vehicle Operating Cost (VOC), better access to rural areas, and improved road governance and maintenance have also not yet fully materialized. By 2021, the average VOC had reduced by 12 percent against an expected 25 percent. Similarly, the objective of improving the access of rural areas to highways was partially met, with 57 percent of the target achieved (239 km out of the expected 439). Regarding improved governance and maintenance, the Road Fund was established and operational, but the Road Authority was in the process of being set up. While these results are promising, interviews revealed that most motorists do not comply with traffic rules, especially with regard to freight load limits, the number of passengers, road signals, and speed limits. In addition, road safety regulations and traffic police are not yet in force. Though connecting the southeast to the rest of the country contributes to promoting inclusivity, minor measurable differences (‘before and after’ changes), such as reduced travel time, are insufficient to substantiate socio-economic benefits for the region or the country.

The evaluation found that the agriculture sector support contributed to the improvement of the trade and commerce environment through increased productivity. SAPEC’s cassava processing hubs produce finished products that are sold in Liberian markets (including supermarkets), increasing local incomes and creating jobs for youth. Destiny Women Inc. reported in interviews that the quantity of cassava processed weekly has increased from 1,000 to 2,600 kilograms, constituting a 160 percent increment, thanks to the integrated cassava processing mill. In interviews, the group reported an increase in overall revenue (undocumented) thanks to trainings received in agribusiness and value addition by SAPEC for 25 beneficiaries (9 male and 16 female).

Additionally, with the knowledge acquired through the SAPEC advisory services provided to 22,380 (2,000 was the target) farming households (of which 30 percent were female-headed), on the use of improved rice seeds and cassava cultivar varieties, Destiny Women Inc. negotiated and secured a contract with Mary Meal, a non-profit organization implementing a school feeding program in Bomi County. As part of this contract, the group supplied 5 Mt of super gari every month for one year in 2019 to the World Food Program (WFP). A portion of the income generated was used to construct a water factory producing water sachets in the City of Bentol to increase revenue.[11] During the COVID-19 pandemic, the group also secured a contract with GoL and supplied 105 Mt of deeper/cassava flour, 24 Mt of fufu, and 70 Mt of gari.

<u>Economic governance and private sector development</u>

The evaluation found that the Bank’s multisector operations contributed to the consolidation of financial control and oversight of government finances. Oversight functions have been consolidated by providing equipment and training to the General Auditing Commission (GAC), enabling the completion and publication of audit reports (13 completed and 36 in draft stages in 2022), including the regularization and audits of the Consolidated Funds Statements. In addition, the efficiency of the new Comptroller and Accountant General Department has improved, as demonstrated by the timeliness in the production of annual financial statements. Furthermore, civil society engagement was strengthened through trainings to increase institutional knowledge of Government and PFM processes and to enhance the quality of their advocacy work on policy engagement, participatory budgeting, transparency and accountability. Production and distribution of budgetary information (citizens’ guides) also enhanced budget transparency. The Liberian Anti-Corruption Commission, established in 2008, was supported by the Bank to promote accountability and better governance for a more efficient use of national resources. There has been a significant

[11] The water factory produces sachets of water. The sale of pre-filtered or sanitized water in plastic and/or heat-sealed bags is popular in Liberia. Water sachets are cheaper to produce than plastic bottles, and easier to transport. This is an added value to the group and enables it to generate more revenue.

increase in the number of corruption cases under investigation, as documented in the draft completion report of the IPFM RP II. The evaluation also found that while oversight functions have been consolidated, there was limited improvement in the follow-up and implementation of audit recommendations. The number of public hearings was overall below target (12 a year, versus the target of 16) except in 2021 when 16 public hearings were held. None were conducted in the first three quarters of 2022.

The evaluation also found that the Bank's multisector operations contributed to a stronger PFM system (fiscal discipline, strategic allocation of resources, and efficient public service delivery). Reinforcing PFM was a key objective of the Bank due to the system's weaknesses and the consequences for public policy implementation, the fight against corruption, and the maintenance of macroeconomic stability. Generally, PFM weaknesses are considered a worrying sign of state fragility. The main areas of improvement included: (i) budget coverage and preparation, including the management of external aid and its integration into the budget (i.e., the quality of sectoral policies and their translation into the annual budget); (ii) cash management through a TSA; (iii) internal audit; and (iv) procurement across the system, including at the sectoral level. In addition, the Bank's support through the IPFM RP projects (Phase I & II) was instrumental for establishing and reinforcing the capacities of the Liberian Revenue Authority (LRA) to strengthen revenue mobilization, notably from natural resources. Besides specific support provided to the LRA, the Bank engaged in policy dialogue with the GoL to implement recommendations of the domestic revenue mobilization strategy, leading to key reforms. As detailed in the CSP 2019-2023 Mid-Term Review (2021), "within the framework of the budget support and Public Financial Management Reforms for Institutional Strengthening Project (PFMRISP), five out of seven ongoing reforms have been completed. These are (i) modernization of excise taxes; (ii) a switch from ad-valorem to specific tax rates; and (iii) excise duty stamps are now in use and a few nonfuel commodities are subject to excise duty. The LRA also completed technical documentation and obtained financing for rolling out Automated System for Customs Data (ASYCUDA) to five rural ports".[12]

However, efforts to improve the procurement process was a constant concern for the Bank and other donors and yielded few positive results. Training and capacity building activities supported under the IPFM RP I did not contribute to improving the procurement process as expected. According to an independent evaluation of the project, "procurement outcomes were well below expectations. The e-procurement module in the IFMIS is not in use. There is no Public Procurement Concession Commission (PPCC) strategy for the management of public procurement in the country. The PPCC does not send instructions with clear guidelines to coordinate ministries and agencies in the preparation, execution and follow-up of procurement plans." This statement is confirmed by the last PEFA assessment (2020), which assigned a "below basic" score for the IP 24 – procurement management.

The evaluation found that the Bank's upstream private sector support through improving the enabling environment remains work in progress. Private sector operations have been slow to materialize due to the challenging business environment in the country, coupled with uncertainties arising during the COVID-19 pandemic. Liberia's business climate remained complex overall and not conducive to greater private sector investment. According to the latest Doing Business survey for Liberia (2020), the country was still ranked among the least attractive countries in the areas of cross-border trade, property registration, electricity distribution and access, and contract enforcement (175 of 190). Nevertheless, improvements in access to credit, starting a business, and fiscal environment indicates that the country is progressing slowly toward greater ease of doing business.

The evaluation found that the Bank's indirect support to SMEs and agribusiness has produced mixed results. Through supporting linkages between producers, processors, and distributors to improve the quality and quantity of agricultural products, the SAPEC project is having a positive impact on income generation and employment creation. However, in agro-forestry, outputs were partly achieved but they have not translated into project level outcomes. This was particularly visible with the SME Wood Processing project, where beneficiaries did not report an increase in sales or improved living conditions, as had been expected. This is mainly because carpenter association members were not sufficiently prepared, trained and coached to develop a business plan, conduct

[12] The UNCTAD Automated System for Customs Data (ASYCUDA) is an integrated customs management system for international trade and transport operations in a modern automated environment.

market research on demand for products, or produce higher quality furniture than that currently available on the market.

Another key area of focus for the AfDB has been supporting the development of value chains in the agriculture sector. This has involved supporting linkages between producers, processors, and distributors to improve the quality and quantity of agricultural products. The case of Destiny Women Inc. is illustrative. Revenues generated by the activity were used to construct additional warehousing facilities for the group.

However, planned agribusiness models to link smallholder farmers to commercial enterprises by way of out-grower schemes did not materialize as expected, despite being highlighted in project reference documents consulted by the evaluation team. For instance, a study conducted by the Farmers Union Network of Liberia in 2017 revealed that local farmers had little or no access to domestic output and input markets, nor did they have direct access to real-time market pricing information. Such information gaps made it harder for farmers to price their products competitively. Advance knowledge of market prices is critical for farmers commuting up to six hours to reach the nearest point of sale. Discussions with the Ministry of Agriculture revealed that the Bank was unable to provide upfront project preparatory funds to conduct feasibility studies that would identify the correct infrastructure inputs, without creating delays in implementation. The one feasibility study that was conducted after project approval did not allocate additional days to the project duration. Linking remote smallholder farmers to commercial enterprises would have enabled real-time information sharing, potentially boosting smallholder revenue generation.

4.2. Knowledge and policy advice

Regarding policy dialogue, the evaluation found that technical and strategic policy dialogue with the Liberian authorities to ensure well-tailored macroeconomic policies were mainly driven by the IMF. Yet the Bank played an active role, especially in providing budget support to the Government. The combination of its lending and non-lending activities, including continuous technical and policy dialogue on priority sectors, provided leverage for maintaining a trusted and open relationship with national authorities despite major delivery interruptions due to Ebola and COVID-19. The EGCSP II provided an opportunity for the COLR to engage in policy dialogue with the new Government on various policy issues addressed by prior actions and triggers (Domestic Resource Mobilization, control of wage bill, TSA, debt monitoring) as well as on the broader development agenda.

The evaluation found that the Bank also pursued policy dialogue with the GoL to implement recommendations of the domestic revenue mobilization strategy, leading to key reforms. As detailed in the 2021 MTR of the second CSP, five out of seven ongoing reforms within the framework of the budget support and PFMRISP operations have been completed. These include: (i) modernization of excise taxes; (ii) a switch from ad-valorem to specific tax rates; and (iii) the implementation of excise duty stamps, with a few nonfuel commodities now subject to excise duty. The LRA also completed technical documentation and obtained financing for rolling out ASYCUDA to five rural ports.

Moreover, the Bank promoted the adoption of a legal framework and provided technical expertise to elaborate strategies and a master plan for SEZ implementation, as well as Government policies in PSD. As mentioned earlier, the feasibility study and Master Plan for the SAIPZ development and a Private Sector Investment Climate Study for Liberia were completed, but the use of these products and their potential impact on the reform process could not be ascertained.

The evaluation found no evidence that knowledge products have been delivered by the Bank in the energy sector during the evaluation period, despite general agreement that the Bank has proven experience in the sector. The evaluation notes that the Bank has been involved in this sector with the preparation of the WAPP CLSG Interconnection project, having a distinct comparative advantage vis-à-vis other partners, making the Bank an ideal partner to identify and deliver specific knowledge products in agreement with Government counterparts. Both CSPs highlighted the aim of ‘transformative infrastructure investments’ (with 80 percent of the portfolio going to energy and transport), which require ‘strengthened capacity and institutions’ to manage project implementation and the significant revenue generation anticipated from energy infrastructure. Yet, no specific knowledge products were provided to reinforce professional capacity within partner institutions.

4.3. Cross-cutting issues

4.3.1. Fragility and resilience

The evaluation found that to reduce the risk of greater instability and violence, the Bank's CSPs pursued complementary strategies and operations designed to address forms of state weakness, increase national integration and foster inclusive economic growth. The CSP 2013-2017, designed to coincide with and complement the Government's AFT, concentrated on constraints to growth, prioritizing energy and transportation as infrastructure bottlenecks that inhibit private sector development, diversification, and greater productivity. It also aimed to address the weak public institutions and constrictive regulatory environment that hampered the Government's investment ambitions and private sector development. The CSP 2019-2023 followed a peaceful political transition in 2018 and a new five-year national development strategy, the Pro-PAPD, and aims to strengthen the country's resilience in close alignment with Liberia's development priorities and the PAPD, while building on work initiated under the first CSP 2013-2017.

The Bank conducted two major Fragility Assessments to ensure the integration of its fragility lens across all interventions. First, prior to the CSP 2013-2017, the AfDB invested in a Retrospective Analysis and Fragility Assessment (2011) to assess previous impact and to identify promising trends to build upon for the next five-year strategy. It highlighted the need to address conflict drivers that had contributed to earlier civil conflicts. These factors were identified as: (i) economic exclusion; (ii) a fragmented society; (iii) limited trust in the state; and (iv) continued security risks. Findings informed the AfDB's decision to upgrade and pave the Fish Town-Harper Road to address economic and social exclusion, a project that carried on through CSP 2019-2023. Secondly, the preparation of the CSP 2019-2023 was informed by the Country Resilience Fragility Assessment (CRFA).

The CSP 2019-2023 emphasized that support to Liberia requires a medium to long-term approach, with continued investment to consolidate the work done under previous cycles. Capacity building comprised a large share of each Bank sector intervention under CSP 2013-2017. Projects promoted regional integration (e.g., MRU Initiative), employment creation, and mainstreaming environmental sustainability and gender equality in their outcomes. The Bank chose to prioritize PFM systems, rule of law, human and institutional capacity development, and combating corruption during CSP 2019-2023. In a deliberate effort to systematically include a fragility lens in its project design, each infrastructure and PFM project contained a strong component of institutional support and capacity building. Additionally, there were many standalone capacity building projects funded by the TSF Pillar III.

The evaluation found that the AfDB also participated closely in policy dialogue, developing partnerships and advocacy around urgent public health issues that threatened to overwhelm government capacity. Governance programs supported improved PFM, including healthcare worker payments. Infrastructure investments, by supporting increased national integration, sought to improve health service delivery. Roads were seen as vital to ending geographic isolation, fostering inclusivity, and rebuilding national identity. Roads are a physical expression of state presence and interest: they open up rural markets, create job opportunities and increase household income. Prevailing feelings of exclusion and abandonment, which have been a source of hostility, would be mitigated. In parallel, the AfDB's efforts to improve governance and transparency in natural resource management would increase trust in state institutions by reducing corruption related to land and natural resources.

Across its two successive CSPs, the AfDB paid particular attention to horizontal inequalities, social exclusion and gender inequalities as drivers of fragility. This was done through promoting equitable access to basic infrastructure, expanding opportunities for private sector-led employment and livelihoods, and supporting the responsible management of natural resources and shared benefits from their revenues. The Bank also supported the Truth and Reconciliation Committee Roadmap, while a Constitutional Review Committee was established to identify areas of conflict and propose amendments to address political exclusion as a key driver of fragility and violence. To support the MRU region's transition out of fragility and instability, the Bank supported the MRU Initiative to unlock constraints on private sector development and trade between Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone, and Guinea through the financing of transportation arteries, energy infrastructure and related projects, such as the construction of customs posts. The Bank also supported the MRU Fragility and Resilience Assessment in 2022 in collaboration with the UN and the MRU Secretariat.

4.3.2. Gender

The evaluation found that Liberia has made progress in addressing gender inequality over the past ten years, but considerable gaps remain. Female and male participation in the labor market is relatively close (69.8 percent among women and 79.7 percent among men in 2021), but women have substantially lower literacy rates than men (34.1 percent against 62.7 percent respectively), notably due to lower access to education. Women also face more difficulties accessing financial services (World Bank, 2023b). According to the United Nations Population Fund Country Representative in Liberia, unplanned (and early) pregnancy is one of the factors that explain the decline in the number of girls completing secondary school.

The AfDB recognizes that gender inequality is a significant obstacle to Africa's development and is committed to promoting gender equality and women's empowerment. In this context, the CSP 2013-2017 prioritized the promotion of gender in project outcomes as one of the important cross-cutting themes of the strategy. The CSP 2019-2023 also places a special emphasis on gender and women's empowerment and aims to tackle gender as one of three critical areas outlined in the 2013-2023 TYS.

The Bank's 2020 CRFA for Liberia included gender inequalities as key driver of fragility. Through the Build Inclusive Business Ecosystems for Stabilization and Transformation (BIBEST) project in the Mano River Union, the Bank is working to address gender considerations and promote women's economic empowerment and social cohesion (AfDB, 2021). Furthermore, in the context of the MRU-1 and MRU-2 (or 80 km Fish Town to Karloken) road projects, field visits confirmed that the contractor and consultant have met Bank criteria for gender and social inclusion. This was evident in the number of youth and women observed working on the project. In the transport sector, local women were included in the short-term employment of road crews during construction periods in Maryland and River Gee counties. In agriculture, female farmer associations such as Destiny Women Inc. were critical to the GoL's emergency response to COVID-19 by supplying processed cassava and other staple items to improve food security for vulnerable families. A pilot effort supporting youth entrepreneurship and professionalization, which included some young women, showed promising results (YEEP), and was well-run by the Ministry of Youth and Sport.

However, apart from regular Bank reporting (IPRs and the occasional MTR), the evaluation found no additional performance management strategies or M&E systems for cross-cutting issues such as gender equity, environment and climate change, and inclusive growth. The tools currently available, such as the supervision mission Aide Memoires and quarterly progress reports, were deemed insufficient in reporting progress. Going forward, with the insistence of the Bank to include M&E officers in project PIUs, COLR is reportedly working with the Bank's Gender division to train the required staff and provide the necessary tools to track and measure gender targets with relevant data. In addition, the Gender division, together with COLR, were expected to identify Category I projects according to the Bank's Gender Marker System, such as those in women-led agriculture value chains and access to finance for SMEs.

4.3.3. Environment and climate change

The GoL, through its Resilience and Adaptation agenda, recognizes the country's vulnerability to climate change and external shocks. According to the 2023 Climate Vulnerability Index, Liberia is among the world's ten most vulnerable countries to climate change and climate-related shocks. This is mainly due to high levels of poverty and extreme dependence on climate sensitive sectors like agriculture, forestry, fisheries, energy and mining, as well as weak institutional capacity to ensure sustainable management of natural resources and adaptation to predicted climatic changes. In fact, although Liberia is endowed with natural resources such as gold, diamonds, iron ore, and timber, only an estimated 5.2 percent of its total land area is arable. This puts significant pressure on Liberians' access to food and nutrition. While the country's vulnerability to natural disasters is moderate, the drive to exploit natural resources has resulted in deforestation, soil erosion, and water pollution, and other ecological problems, especially in areas where illegal miners operate. As a result, ensuring responsible and sustainable mining practices is a challenge for Liberia as it seeks to balance economic development with environmental preservation. This suggests ample room to improve capacity in this area.

The AfDB recognizes the threats that environmental and climate change pose to Africa's development and is committed to promoting environmental sustainability. Through grants and the Climate Investment Funds, the Bank aims to help African countries mitigate the effects of climate change by promoting renewable energy, sustainable agriculture, and low-carbon transport (AfDB, 2022). Both CSPs emphasized environment and climate change. In this context, the Bank also acknowledged that in addition to improving public health and fostering economic development, the water and sanitation sector in Liberia plays a vital role for environmental sustainability. Furthermore, COLR recognizes that efforts are required to (i) strengthen climate change and green growth mainstreaming at project design; (ii) ensure effective implementation of climate and green growth measures at project implementation stage; and (iii) support climate finance resources mobilization.

The evaluation found that the Bank ensured that environmental and social safeguards were identified through dedicated studies in advance of its operations. These studies were consulted by the evaluation team. Both the energy and transport sectors conducted preliminary environmental impact studies (Environmental and Social Management Plan [ESMP], Resettlement Action Plan [RAP] studies) and implemented these safeguards during the construction phases. For instance, the SREP program for 2015 experienced a slow start-up period due to the recruitment of consultants and completion of the Environmental and Social Impact Assessment. Consequently, the project started in 2017. Similarly, during a project site visit in the context of this evaluation, it was observed that the MPW met the Bank's requirements for environmental impact studies for the MRU 1&2 projects, ensuring that project-affected populations were resettled and that endangered species were preserved in their habitats.

The Bank supported the GoL's efforts to promote environmental sustainability through some targeted operations. The Bank is currently supporting the development of Liberia's Long-Term Strategy, which will guide the country's plans toward realizing net zero targets by 2050. In addition, the Bank recently approved the sum of UA 500,000 for Liberia to support the formalization of artisanal small-scale mining (ASM). The overall goal of this project is to improve formalization, efficiency, and environmental management practices in the ASM sub-sector. The ongoing project aims at: (i) improvement in ASM related data availability for natural resource policy development; (ii) improved regulation of the ASM sector; strengthened institutional capacity to manage the ASM sub-sector; (iii) enhanced capacity of ASMs for efficient and sustainable mining and processing practices; (iv) ASMs integrated into the formal economy; and (v) improved health, safety and security issues in ASM and reduction in environmental degradation, especially deforestation, pollution and siltation of water courses and mercury emissions from mining operations.

However, the evaluation found that some practical challenges remain regarding the implementation of E&S measures and the M&E efforts to promote environmental sustainability. These are: (i) the weak monitoring capacity of public institutions given their limited autonomy in all other areas of oversight and management; (ii) recurrent failure of project implementing units to deliver timely E&S quarterly and monthly implementation reports and annual E&S performance audit reports, which are required for all moderate and high risk projects, in line with the Bank's ISS; (iii) delays in RAP implementation due to non-availability of counterpart funding; and (iv) the poor quality of environmental and social assessment reports prepared by the client for moderate and high- risk projects and disclosed prior to appraisal and Board deliberation, usually observed during project preparation phase. The Bank's E&S department is reportedly planning to address these challenges through capacity building sessions for project staff, various agencies, and institutions.

4.4. Sustainability

Sustainability refers to the extent to which the interventions' benefits continue or are likely to continue after the completion of the Bank's support. The main dimensions considered are: (i) technical soundness; (ii) financial and economic viability; (iii) institutional capacity and ownership by beneficiaries; and (iv) environmental and social sustainability.

The evaluation assessed the sustainability of the Bank's support to Liberia's development as partly unsatisfactory overall, with significant weaknesses in institutional capacity and measures for ensuring financial sustainability and ownership *of Bank interventions in the medium to long-term. However, technical soundness and environmental and social sustainability were found satisfactory.*

4.4.1. Technical soundness

Despite some minor shortcomings, the technical soundness of the Bank's operations throughout the two strategic cycles is rated satisfactory.

In the transport sector, field visits and site inspections found the roadworks to be up to standard, and expected to withstand erosion due to heavy rains and drainage for the immediate future. Construction of main arteries appears to respect international norms and standards. However, while some connecting roads were well designed and built, others were seemingly haphazard and prone to future erosion. Indeed, reports from project site visits indicate poor quality of intersections with feeder roads. The evaluation found that poor planning and design of intersections could reduce the long-term utility and value addition of the roads. It found little dedicated analysis or planning to anticipate how newly paved roads would connect and serve agricultural production projects funded by the Bank and other DPs, apart from the two markets built along the Pleebo road.

Similarly, in the agro-forestry sub-sector, the evaluation found no evidence that beneficiaries were applying their business development training (marketing, entrepreneurship) to their wood processing operations. Translating this support into a viable business model for participating SMEs did not transpire as expected. The bulk of funding was spent on staff salaries, vehicle rentals, and office management. Furniture sales by carpentry associations, for instance, are negligible according to Forestry Development Authority staff and SME beneficiaries. SMEs were reportedly unable to successfully complete the application process to access micro-finance loans, which was another project outcome.

4.4.2. Financial and economic sustainability

Financial sustainability was rated partly unsatisfactory across all CSP pillars and sectors, with the exception of governance projects, due to inadequate resources for the operation and maintenance of services.

The evaluation found that the financial sustainability of almost all governance projects was largely satisfactory (except the IPFM RP II). This assessment is based on measures adopted to consolidate macroeconomic stability, increase domestic resource mobilization, and reinforce PFM. It is nevertheless acknowledged that the country remains fragile and vulnerable to shocks with low buffers and a high risk of overall public debt distress. In the long-term, financial sustainability will largely depend on Government capacity to sustain resources for stakeholders to conduct their duties (LRA, MACs, Liberia Institute of Public Administration, Ministry of Finance and Development Planning).

The evaluation also found that the sustainability of roads (construction underway) is not guaranteed in the absence of mandated, fully operational institutions to collect road use revenue and manage regular maintenance. The longevity of these roads and their supporting infrastructure (drainage channels, axle load weighing stations, etc.) depend entirely on the quality of maintenance that the MPW and its supporting institutions can provide. However, sustainability in terms of maintenance—specifically the technical and managerial capacity to conduct regular road maintenance, and the ability to generate and manage revenue from road users (through tolling systems, vehicle and fuel tax)—is doubtful. Both the AfDB and World Bank consider the sustainability of their road transport investments to be at high risk due to concerns about future maintenance.

The evaluation also found that the requirements for future road maintenance are not yet in place. Although years in development, the National Road Fund (NRF) is not yet applying vehicle tolls to generate revenue for road maintenance and safety programming, including the long-awaited axle load weighing stations. Even with a sound revenue generation system in place to fund future maintenance, revenue by itself is no guarantee that maintenance will be prioritized in the national roads budget, or that capable contractors are trained, hired and paid to maintain the roads. Interviews indicated mixed reviews of the NRF, both in terms of its progress in generating and maintaining revenue flows, and its ability to channel those funds into well-managed maintenance crews operating in remote regions. The MPW concentration in Monrovia was repeatedly cited as a serious constraint on future maintenance and financial sustainability.

The evaluation found the financial sustainability of the Bank's investments in the energy sector to be inadequate. Therefore, expected benefits of the Bank's energy projects may be difficult to sustain unless measures to enhance their financial viability are put in place. Bank support to the sector suffered long delays in project development and delivery, but reportedly enjoyed a solid partnership with the GoL. As already discussed above, the electricity tariff decreased significantly from its 2012 baseline of USD 0.52 per kWh. The current tariff of USD 0.25 per kWh is still one of the highest rates in the world.

With the LEC facing significant challenges in fulfilling its mission of improving access to reliable and affordable electricity, high debts, high operating costs relative to electricity consumption, the failure of customers to pay electricity bills, and the high cost of diesel fuel for the generators, altogether represent significant hinderances for its financial sustainability. The LEC has inadequate resources, equipment, and tools to maintain the country's limited energy infrastructure, and is severely hampered by extremely high non-technical losses (unauthorized electricity usage comprises 49 to 60 percent of losses). LEC is also hampered by limited technical capacity, partly due to Liberia's loss of professionals following the war and Ebola. Poor quality education and training programs further limit the number and capacity of new Liberian professionals entering the energy sector.

The current high cost of imported energy is financially unsustainable for the GoL. High energy costs deter investment and block private sector development. The three major successive crises that befell Liberia over the past ten years resulted in inflation, procurement delays, and severe fuel shortages. Although the energy projects supported by the two CSPs are still underway and have therefore been unable to realize their goal of lower energy costs for Liberians at the time of this evaluation, the consistently high cost of energy in Liberia (as a net importer) has direct consequences for the cost of doing business generally in the county, as well as the cost of living for its citizens. Liberia's transition out of fragility to a more resilient and self-sufficient state will depend largely on its ability to generate and distribute its own power—a goal the Bank has fully supported over the 2013-2023 period.

4.4.3. Institutional capacity and ownership

The institutional capacity and ownership of the Bank's operations in Liberia throughout the two CSP cycles is rated partly unsatisfactory.

In the governance sector, the Bank prioritized capacity building and workforce development to strengthen its institutional partners and increase the impact and sustainability of its investments. PBOs used country PFM systems and involved the GACs, the Central Bank of Liberia, the Comptroller and Accountant General for internal audits. This shows the responsiveness of GoL partner institutions to fulfill their mandate using improved systems provided by the Bank and other DPs. As institutional strengthening was a key element of all programs, including policy documents incorporated in the operational plans of the institutions and trained staff still on duty, the collaboration of the above government institutions offers some short-term evidence of new systems and trainings being put into practice. Nevertheless, institutional capacity remains limited, and the sustainability in the medium to long-term is not guaranteed.

The evaluation found that strong attention was given to ensuring institutional ownership and leadership by national authorities in the governance sector, with the exception of two PBOs. This attention was to ensure continuous involvement of national authorities during the formulation and implementation of projects. However, this was not the case for the EGCSP II and the COVID-19 Response. Both were negotiated and implemented in a short period of time, with limited scope for involving all stakeholders in the design and the implementation. During implementation, the lack of coordination arrangements made it difficult to get information from the GoL on the progress of the different measures.

However, the evaluation found that the integration of workforce development into the Bank's budget support in PFM did not translate into credible ownership by counterpart institutions. Technical capacity building was incorporated into the Bank's strategy and approach under both CSPs to promote sustainable outcomes. Although sustainability was positively assessed by most completion reports, except for the IPFM RP Phase II (draft completion report), this evaluation finds that sustainability is not guaranteed given the limited financial and managerial capacity across all beneficiary MACs. A classic symptom of fragility, the low professional capacity at all levels of public administration continues to impede lasting, sustainable outcomes in the governance sector.

In the transport sector, the evaluation identified low institutional capacity as a threat to the sustainability of the Bank's investments. Institutional sustainability in the sector is limited due to management capacity among leading institutions, primarily the Ministry of Public Works. Historically, roads in Liberia have not been maintained by the State. To address this issue, the AfDB through its 'Technical Assistance to the Ministry of Public Works' project financed from 2019 to 2023, supported workforce training and professional capacity building for MPW staff, including short-term trainings. In this context, some participants went on to complete academic degrees in urban planning and public management. However, it is too early to assess the impact of individual training assistance on the performance of large national institutions such as the MPW, or its ability to ensure the sustainability of the Bank's investments in the national transport network.

The evaluation also found that the Bank advocated for a number of transport sector reforms to ensure the longevity and ownership of its investments by more resilient and robust institutions. These reforms, some of which are still incomplete, include: (i) establishment of the National Road Fund (2016) to ensure coordination in the sector with multi-donor support to promote alignment with national development priorities in the transport sector; (ii) support to the development of the Axle Load Law (2015) and the installation of axle loading controls to weigh trucks, which is expected to protect roads and ensure financial sustainability of the road networks and regular maintenance; and (iii) the MPW oversight of the NRF on revenue generation from its future toll system, vehicle taxes, and fuel levies to promote road safety by checking truck weight and controlling cargo contents. However, the impact of these institutional reforms on the sustainability of the Bank's transport projects cannot be fully assessed until the reforms are fully implemented.

At the same time, the evaluation found that key transport sector stakeholders met routinely at every stage of the project to inform each other about the progress and challenges of the project. These included the MPW, the Ministry of Defense, local Government authority, project-affected communities, Bank representatives, the PIU, the contractor, and consultants. Efforts to foster local ownership during the planning and construction phases involved including local authorities and public representatives in sessions to inform the population about the plans, timelines, and outcomes of the construction works before they commenced. Stakeholder meetings were held before construction in a settlement area, and local authorities were present to answer questions from the public. To further increase local ownership and build trust through open communication lines, periodic stakeholder meetings were organized to identify any social and environmental issues raised by the project. Interviews conducted during the field visits confirmed that local stakeholders and beneficiaries were involved at every stage of the project. Contractors described this approach as participatory.

In agriculture, capacity building activities are much needed, nevertheless, the impact of these activities on long-term institutional sustainability and ownership is not yet measurable. Under SAPEC, the AfDB supported the Ministry of Agriculture to train undergraduate and graduate students as agriculture extension agents and vocational technicians in various agricultural disciplines. Beneficiaries from these trainings are now supporting the sector to sustainably manage the maintenance of marketplaces, technology transfer and agribusiness centers, as well as the rehabilitation of feeder roads to provide market access to rural farmer communities. Significant effort was made to design tailored institutional support for partner institutions and associations. Nonetheless, the evaluation found little evidence of this support being translated into practice and that beneficiary institutions have sufficient resources to maintain the equipment received, despite technicians being trained to use it.

In addition, the lack of prioritization of project outputs by beneficiary learning institutions represents a threat for the sustainability of technical inputs. For example, laboratories completed in the context of the SAPEC were handed over to the University of Liberia's Faculty of Agriculture, but they remained unused for two years. The equipment provided could not be used due to a lack of technical staff to calibrate the devices. Furthermore, there was no in-house technical staff available to set up the computers and upload the requisite software to enable teaching and learning at the college. Delays by the University to operationalize the facility resulted in the damage of air conditioners, sets of desktop computers, and the expiration of most chemicals and reagents. Up to the time of the evaluation team's visit, the computer laboratories were not yet functional.

4.4.4. Environmental and social sustainability

The long-term environmental and social sustainability of the Bank's investments under the two CSPs is assessed as satisfactory overall, despite some shortcomings.

Both the energy and transport sectors conducted preliminary environmental impact studies (ESMP, RAP studies) and implemented these safeguards during their construction phase. Safeguards in both these sectors were identified in advance through dedicated studies that were consulted by the evaluation team. For the REEL and YEEP energy projects, however, RAP studies were delayed due to slow Government counterpart funding. Additionally, during the field visit, affected populations reported that they had not been directly consulted, but only through their representatives. Omissions such as these can adversely affect the social sustainability of Bank investments, where popular support and local ownership are envisioned by program designs. For the LEEAP project, no RAP was needed because it did not affect housing, and GoL consulted and confirmed with affected communities that no repeat compensation payments would be respected. Other short-term impacts on flora and fauna are deemed minimal and manageable.

One area of concern for environmental and social sustainability is the agro-forestry project supporting SMEs in wood processing. It was noted that no reforestation component was included in the project, which relied on raw timber supplies. No environmental sustainability considerations were formalized by the wood processing project for SMEs.

5. HAS THE BANK UNDERTAKEN ITS INTERVENTIONS IN THE RIGHT WAY?

5.1. Efficiency

Efficiency refers to the degree to which an intervention delivers, or is likely to deliver, results in an economical and timely manner. The evaluation assessed: (i) the timeliness in project start-up and completion; and (ii) returns on public investment.

The efficiency of the AfDB support to Liberia was found to be partly unsatisfactory. Most of the interventions suffered from significant start-up and implementation delays. Despite generally sound public investment management practices, the evaluation could not compile a comprehensive picture of the returns on public investment in Liberia. However, weak project results point to partly unsatisfactory returns on investment.

5.1.1. Timeliness

The timeliness of Bank operations under the two CSP cycles is rated partly unsatisfactory. **Start-up delays characterized almost the entire AfDB portfolio in Liberia, especially in the energy, transport and agricultural sectors** (see Table 5). For example, the LEEAP, initially programmed for Board approval in 2014, was approved nearly three years later in early 2017. The SREP program for 2015 was indeed approved in 2015 but became effective only in 2017. In the agriculture sector, the SAPEC project entered into force on 17 July 2013, but the first disbursement was made only on 7 May 2015.

Table 5: Timeframes of AfDB sector approvals and disbursements in Liberia[13], 2013-2023

Indicators		Economic governance	Infrastructure	Agriculture	All projects
Board approval to signature (months)	Average	2	2	1.7	2.2
	Percentage of delayed operations	23%	4%	20%	17%
Signature to effectiveness (months)	Average	1.1	5	0	2.6
	Percentage of delayed operations	19%	50%	0%	28%
Effectiveness to 1st disbursement	Average	2.4	5	4.3	3.5
	Percentage of delayed operations	31%	54%	80%	43%
Approval to 1st disbursement	Average	2	11.8	5.6	8
	Percentage of delayed operations	6%	67%	40%	47%
Average project extensions	Average time	8.4	15	-	9.5
	Percentage of delayed operations	50%	100%		64%

Source: Calculated by the evaluation team based on the SAP extraction and project documents, 2023.

Similarly, most operations were not delivered on time. They suffered from significant implementation delays to the extent that their original closing dates had to be extended at least once. Their disbursement was lagging relative to their age (see Table 6). As indicated in Table 5, 64 percent of Bank projects in Liberia were extended at least once, with an average of 9.5 months of extensions granted. Among the ongoing operations, ten (or more than half), had been approved during the 2013-2018 period, indicating that the portfolio is struggling with implementation delays. For example, all AfDB-funded road construction projects in Liberia required multiple extensions of their implementation timeframes. The scaling up the participation of SMEs in the secondary wood processing industry project, originally scheduled for 2019-2020, was extended to 2022. However, a few AfDB-funded operations, especially in the multi-sector domain, were delivered within the intended timeframes. In the governance sector, the Ebola Sector Budget Support–Fight Back Programme (EFBP) operation was approved and fully disbursed within the same fiscal year. The COVID-19 Technical Assistance was also processed within three months, and the funds were disbursed three weeks thereafter.

The average age of the active portfolio across all sectors is 5.3 years (or 64.5 months), which is above the regional average. During the 2013–23 period, the Bank disbursed a total of UA 347.6 million, while approvals for the period amounted to UA 388.9 million. As of December 2023, 39 percent of the Bank's portfolio in Liberia comprised flagged projects, which is above the regional average.

Two NSOs were canceled: the Maryland Oil Palm Plantation approved in 2013 and the Trade Finance Line of Credit to Ecobank approved in 2017. However, cancellations represent less than 1 percent of total commitments in the country and the portfolio does not contain any problem projects.

[13] The standard in force during the evaluation period was three months from approval to signature, three months from signature to effectiveness, three months from effectiveness to the first disbursement, and six months from approval to the first disbursement (Presidential Directive 2015).

Table 6: Age of operations relative to their disbursement rate by sector

Key Sector	Average age of operations (years)	Disbursement rate (percent)
Multisector	2.8	65
Agriculture	6.7	73.6
Energy	3.3	9.3
Transport	5.9	60

Source: Calculated by the evaluation team based on the SAP extraction and project documents, 2023.

The key contributory factors to the start-up and implementation delays of the AfDB support over the 2013-2023 period comprise the following: (i) lengthy administrative processes slowing down the AfDB approvals, and GoL payment approval; (ii) GoL's difficulties in complying with counterpart funding, implementation of resettlement action plans, and setting up and managing of project implementation management units; (iii) insufficient GoL and AfDB staff capacities for the efficient delivery of the AfDB support; (iv) multiple crisis (Ebola, COVID-19, and Russia's invasion of Ukraine) and their negative effects; and (v) heavy rains, and their negative effects especially on road construction.

5.1.2. Returns on public investment

The Return on Investment of Bank operations under the two CSPs under study is not rated. None of the 18 completed AfDB operations report on the returns on public investment. However, most of the interventions judiciously utilized their budget allocations to deliver their expected outputs, thereby avoiding the need for additional resources. One of the transport projects, FTHRP, also recorded savings of at least UA 8.61 million. At the same time, one project in the agriculture sector showed efficiency defects. The project aimed at scaling up participation in the secondary processing industry had a low return on investment, mainly because it under-delivered on training SMEs and generating sales revenue from the finished wood products. During its field mission, the evaluation team found, through observation and stakeholder interviews, the sales of finished wood products to be negligible.

5.2. Partnerships and leverage

Evidence shows that the Bank has built strong partnerships with other DPs at both sector and project levels. In the energy sector, the coordination among DPs benefits from an energy sector working group. The Bank is also part of the Agriculture Sector Donor Working Group chaired by the Minister of Agriculture in Liberia, and which includes USAID, EU, and FAO. The Bank's transport interventions are well coordinated and coherent with the World Bank Group and SIDA. In the governance sector, budget support operations were designed and elaborated in connection with the other DPs, including the WHO, UNICEF, World Bank, and USAID.

The Bank mobilized approximately UA 115.5 million from other DPs and UA 59.1 million from trust funds or initiatives at the global and regional levels. The AfDB is financing the LEEAP, the CLSG Interconnection project, and the CLSG Rural Electrification project, which are co-financed by the World Bank's Scaling Up Renewable Energy Program (SREP). The EU, which is also providing support to other energy sector players, is co-financing the LEEAP.

5.3. Managing for development results

The evaluation found that the CSPs' and operations' M&E systems and processes were adequately designed. However, these systems were inadequately operationalized and utilized. Furthermore, support for national and Bank M&E capacity building and management was deemed limited.

Both CSPs and projects' M&E systems and processes are underpinned by results-based frameworks. They were designed to use the existing M&E frameworks for the Liberia AFT and PAPD, with the GoL and AfDB having joint responsibility for resourcing, implementing and reporting. At both the CSP and operational levels, the two CSPs and their projects were found to have clear M&E strategies and be results-focused; they clearly define their expected results (especially the outputs and outcomes), indicators and associated baselines, targets, and reporting tools.

However, the results-based frameworks of the two CSPs were missing some intermediate indicators. For example, in the agriculture sector, the proposed indicator concerning annual rice import is of high order. Although the products of the two Bank CSPs focus on improving the productivity and revenues of farmers and other actors in the agriculture and food chain, appropriate indicators on agricultural productivity and revenue are missing in the CSP results chains. In addition, some of the project M&E strategies are silent on cross-cutting themes including gender equity, inclusive growth, environment, and climate change.

The AfDB delivered country portfolio performance reviews (CPPRs) based on the results of field supervision missions, stakeholder interviews/discussions, and analyses of its operations database. Such CPPRs were the basis for the continuous portfolio improvement plans. However, the Bank was not able to attain its target of annual portfolio improvement reviews over the period of the two CSPs. In addition, the Bank undertook the MTR of the CSP 2013-2018, which was useful in the continuous improvement of the design and implementation of the subsequent CSP. It also undertook the MTR of the CSP 2019-2023; with the completion report due in 2025.

Regarding individual operations, the Bank produced, among other products, IPRs and PCRs for continuous improvement of its portfolio, and accounting for project results. Although the IPRs, based on project supervisions, provided useful contents, they were found to have shortcomings. For example, the Bank was not able to reach its overall target of 80 percent of projects supervised at least twice a year, and most IPRs provide limited analyses. To contribute to enhancing project M&E capacity, the Bank provided fiduciary clinics. Such clinics, though useful, were neither M&E focused nor supplied in adequate quantity. Furthermore, the evaluation found no evidence of AfDB Technical Assistance on M&E capacity building over the period of the two CSPs.

M&E strategies at the CSP and project levels were not found to be adequately implemented. This was mainly due to: (i) the weak capacity of GoL and of the AfDB country office (especially the absence of a Country Program Officer), and (ii) the lack of appropriate incentives to attract and retain competent staff. The evaluation found that COLR was operating under a significant level of stress due to staffing positions not being filled. In fact, out of the 17 projects currently in the portfolio, only five projects in one sector (energy), are managed from the country office. The remaining 12 projects are managed from other locations, making project supervision challenging. In addition, given the workload of the energy sector expert due to responsibility for additional projects in other countries, the level of field supervision in Liberia has not been optimal. Furthermore, the Country Program Officer position remained vacant for three years.

6. CONCLUSIONS, LESSONS, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1. Conclusion

The evaluation concludes that the Bank's support responded to the immediate needs of the GoL and its population as defined in the two successive national development agendas. It was also found to be aligned with AfDB's institutional policies and strategies. The Bank's assistance across both CSPs was designed to address the main drivers of fragility identified in specific sectors and demonstrated flexibility in adapting to changing circumstances. However, the lack of systematic contextualization of the hypotheses and assumptions in the design represent an important risk for the achievement of higher-level objectives such as inclusive growth. The evaluation rated relevance as satisfactory.

The Bank's portfolio showed good coordination and synergies within each sector. However, the evaluation identified a weakness in the internal coherence with respect to the Bank's commitment to developing PPPs in the energy sector. The evaluation also found evidence of strong coordination with other DPs at sector level, with increased regularity of interactions to support the country's response to the Ebola crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. However, external coherence between the multiple actors could have benefited from a stronger coordination by Liberian authorities at sector level. Overall, coherence is rated as satisfactory.

The Bank's effectiveness in achieving outputs and outcomes through its CSPs in Liberia is rated as partly unsatisfactory, as only 40 percent of the expected outputs and 27 percent of the expected outcomes were met at the time of the evaluation. The evaluation highlighted that while some expected outputs and outcomes were achieved, only a few cases of full achievement were observed, and many gaps remained. However, a number of additional outputs (47 percent) and outcomes (41 percent) are likely to be achieved in the short or medium term. Given the transition country status of Liberia, the remaining outcomes may take time to materialize. For example, with implementation delays in key sectors such as transport and energy, the evaluation found it difficult to fully account for the Bank's effectiveness in laying the foundations for inclusive economic growth and diversification until these projects are completed. The evaluation also found that the Bank's contribution to improving economic governance and PSD had some mixed results.

The sustainability of the Bank's support to Liberia's development was rated partly unsatisfactory, with significant weaknesses in institutional capacity and measures for ensuring financial sustainability and ownership of Bank interventions in the medium to long-term. However, the long-term environmental and social sustainability and the technical soundness of the Bank's investments under the two CSPs is assessed as generally satisfactory.

Most Bank-financed interventions suffered from significant start-up and implementation delays. Despite generally sound public investment management practices, the evaluation could not compile a comprehensive picture of the returns on public investment in Liberia. However, weak project results point to partly negative returns on investment. Efficiency is therefore rated as partly unsatisfactory.

6.2. Lessons

The following are the key lessons from this evaluation:

- **Adaptation and flexibility of programs are crucial for post-crisis recovery in transition environments.** The responsiveness of the Bank and other DPs to both the Ebola and COVID-19 crises in public health and other critical sectors, such as food security, helped avert further damage. Interviews with stakeholders confirmed that these rapid responses were instrumental in containing the two pandemics and stimulating economic recovery.
- **A holistic approach is required to systematically link improved infrastructure and logistics to positive higher-level outcomes.** The Bank's support to improve infrastructure and logistics in the productive sectors, through the construction of market facilities and rural access roads, did not systematically translate into positive outcomes. In this case, poor domestic demand hindered the acceleration of local trade through increasing access to market opportunities for farmers. A holistic approach which aims to integrate rural roads, transportation stakeholders, and urban distribution systems can better connect infrastructure investments (such as enhancing energy distribution, reducing costs, developing feeder roads, generating road revenue streams, and building transport maintenance capacity) with agricultural value chain development, and thus yield better results.
- **Ex-ante market research and value chain studies can improve project design in production sectors such as agriculture, agro-forestry and SME support.** Between 2013 and 2023, neither CSP attempted to analyze or develop plausible synergies between new transport infrastructure, increased agricultural production, and the new commercial opportunities being created. Undertaking value chain and market studies to inform these project designs can strengthen how they contribute to CSP pillar-level results.
- **Building Government capacity is key for successful planning and implementation in transition countries**. Despite Bank support on the capacity building front, major capacity constraints, particularly in the public sector, were still found to exist and to pose challenges in the successful implementation of Bank projects.

6.3. Recommendations

The evaluation proposes the following recommendations for the next Liberia CSP.

1. **Continue Bank support to the transport, energy, and governance sectors to reinforce progress made toward reducing fragility and building resilience**. Priority actions include:
   - Prioritizing support to efforts that enhance the sustainability of results already achieved in key strategic sectors.
   - Integrating mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of benefits of Bank operations at the design stage, for effective implementation.
   - Strengthening internal coherence by building more complementarity and synergies between past and new interventions in key strategic sectors.
   - Building synergies between indirect support to agribusiness and SMEs and (previous and future) operations in the transport and energy sectors.

2. **Improve the design of Bank operations for better achievement of higher-level strategic objectives.** Priority actions include:
   - Better integration of national, local, and sector context analysis into the design of operations in key sectors.
   - Undertaking studies to enhance understanding of structural context-specific factors that hinder the achievement of results.
   - Improving the participation of local stakeholders and beneficiaries in the design of operations targeting specific regions or areas.
   - Anticipating systemic and structural institutional issues inherent to the fragility context of Liberia.

3. **Improve the mainstreaming and monitoring of cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and Bank operations to enhance effectiveness.** Priority actions include:
   - Systematically identifying the structural causes and impacts of the cross-cutting issues relevant to Liberia (fragility, gender inequality, environment and climate change, youth, and regional integration).
   - Specifying objectives at the design stage.
   - Establishing and systematically utilizing M&E mechanisms to monitor progress and address issues when required.

4. **Improve the quality of CSP Results Framework design, measurement, and reporting of results by linking results at the sector and CSP pillar levels.** Priority actions include:
   - Improving the reliability, feasibility, and causal relationships in the results chain.
   - Establishing a comprehensive set of indicators and corresponding baselines covering the higher-level pillar-related outcomes that are traceable to AfDB actions.
   - Ensuring realism and adequacy between the fragility context of Liberia, resource allocation, and targeted results.
   - Using existing statistical reporting systems and identifying proxies for the strategic results that the Bank intends to contribute toward.

5. **Maintain strong coordination with other DPs to further enhance development effectiveness.** Priority actions include:
   - Incentivizing government ownership through Technical Assistance in strategic sectors of the Bank’s interventions.
   - Undertaking detailed sector-specific stakeholder mapping in key sectors.
   - Developing structured interactions around a clear agenda with a long-term perspective with all concerned ministries, private sector representatives, CSOs, and DPs involved in relevant sectors.

ANNEXES

ANNEX 1: Summary Methodological Approach

The evaluation's overall methodological approach is based on an inception report produced after a scoping mission conducted. It defines the scope of the evaluation and outlines a three-phase process that would be followed, namely: inception, data collection and reporting.

The evaluation followed a pyramidal approach, which combined three levels of analysis: (i) country strategies (CSPs); (ii) thematic /CSP pillar/ priority areas; and (iii) projects. This section provides summarized information on data collection methods and the rating scale used for the evaluation. For a more detailed description of the methodology, see Technical Annex 2.

Data Collection

To ensure that the assessment was based on evidence, the evaluation adopted a mixed-methods approach using the following methods:

- Desk review of key documentation.
- Interviews and focus group discussions**.** The evaluation team conducted a total of 85 individual or group interviews. A list of individuals/organizations interviewed is included in Technical Annex 3.
- Field visits and direct observation.
- Secondary data analysis: on the economic, social and institutional situation of Liberia as well as performance monitoring data to complement documentary reviews.

Data Analysis

To address analysis at the different levels, the evaluation conducted the following:

Desk review of key documentation. The evaluation team conducted an extensive document review. Team members consulted the Government's strategies and plans, the Bank's strategies and programs, secondary materials relevant to the country context, other pertinent evaluations, and reports from development partners (DPs).

Portfolio review. The team performed a comprehensive analysis of the Bank's portfolio, gathering information about its nature and composition, distribution across sectors, and implementation status.

Key Informant Interviews and focus group discussions. The evaluation team conducted virtual and in-person interviews and consultations with a wide range of stakeholders (Technical Annex 2) within the Bank and in the country. These stakeholders included officials in government ministries and executing agencies, Bank staff, DPs, the private sector, and civil society organizations. The team also interviewed project beneficiaries during project site visits.

Project Results Assessments (PRAs). All projects with a disbursement rate exceeding 75 percent - 17 in total- were analyzed using a PRA grid, derived from the Evaluation Matrix. The PRA primarily relies on qualitative sources of information, such as documentation review, interviews, and focus group discussions conducted with key informants. Interventions with a less than 75 percent disbursement rate (16 projects) were analyzed using a synthetic fiche focusing on the relevance, coherence and sustainability of these projects. This approach was chosen because these projects are not advanced enough to allow for a full assessment of their efficiency, effectiveness, and sustainability**.**

ANNEX 2: Rating Scale

The evaluation criteria adopted are in line with the practices set out in the Revised OECD/DAC criteria as well as ECG's Good Practice Standards for the Evaluation of Public Sector Operations: relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency and sustainability. Each criterion encompassed within the intervention assessment grid was assigned a score based on a rating scale. This rating scale aims to ensure sound qualitative assessment based on evidence derived from the documentary analysis, individual or collective exchanges with stakeholders, general or sector specific development data, descriptive statistics, etc. It makes explicit the basis of the assessment (argumentation), facilitates the comparability between projects and fosters common understanding of the specific intervention's performance. The rating scale has four levels ranging from 1 (unsatisfactory) to 4 (highly satisfactory).

Table A2.1 The evaluation's four-point rating scales

Scale	1 Unsatisfactory	2 Partly unsatisfactory	3 Satisfactory	4 Highly satisfactory
Relevance	▪ Very weak, very inappropriate design and very limited/non-existent alignment	▪ Weak, improper design and limited alignment / several gaps	▪ Rather strong and appropriate design, strong alignment	▪ Very solid and appropriate design, complete alignment
Coherence	▪ Very weak synergy ▪ Very weak coordination	Weak synergy Weak coordination	▪ Strong synergy ▪ Strong coordination	▪ Best practice for synergy creation and coordination
Effectiveness	▪ Expected outputs not achieved in most cases ▪ No or very few targeted results achieved	▪ Expected outputs achieved with significant gaps ▪ Few targeted results achieved	▪ Expected outputs achieved in most cases ▪ Most targeted results achieved	▪ Expected outputs fully achieved ▪ All targeted results achieved
Efficiency	▪ Very significant difference between the ERR and the opportunity cost of capital ▪ Very significant gap between planned and actual timing of implementation	▪ Significant difference between the ERR and the opportunity cost of capital ▪ Significant gap between planned and actual timing of implementation	▪ Moderate difference between the ERR and the opportunity cost of capital ▪ Moderate gap between planned and actual timing of implementation	▪ Little or no difference between the ERR and the opportunity cost of capital ▪ Little or no difference between planned and actual timing of implementation
Sustainability	▪ Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are not assured	▪ Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are hindered by significant risks	▪ Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are generally ensured, with minor risks	▪ Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are fully assured

References

ADE. (2020). *Evaluation of the AfDB group strategy for addressing fragility and building resilience in Africa 2014-2019 Case Study Report - Liberia.*

AfDB. (2020). *West Africa. Regional Integration Strategy Paper 2025-2025.* African Development Bank.

AfDB. (2015). *Liberia energy efficiency and access project.* Retrieved from https://www.afdb.org/fileadmin/uploads/afdb/Documents/Environmental-and-Social-Assessments/Liberia_-_Liberia_energy_efficiency_and_access_project_%E2%80%93_ESMP-ARAP_Summary.pdf

AfDB. (2019). *BANK GROUP COUNTRY STRATEGY PAPER 2019-2023 for Liberia.*

AfDB. (2021). *SIMPLIFIED PROJECT APPRAISALREPORT. Project to Build Inclusive Business Ecosystems for Stabilization and Transformation in the Mano River Union (BI-BEST) – Technical assistanceand capacity development.* African Development Bank Group.

AfDB. (2022). *Country Focus Report 2022. Liberia. Supporting Climate Resilience and a Just Energy Transition.* African Development Bank Group.

AfDB. (2022). *Liberia Economic Outlook*. Retrieved from Liberia: https://www.afdb.org/en/countries/west-africa/liberia/liberia-economic-outlook#:~:text=GDP%20growth%20fell%20to%20an,spending%20on%20the%20demand%20side.

AfDB. (2022a). *Liberia economic outlook*. Retrieved from https://www.afdb.org/en/countries/west-africa/liberia

AfDB. (2022b). *African Economic Outlook 2022.* Retrieved from https://www.afdb.org/en/documents/african-economic-outlook-2022

AfDB. (2023, March 21). *African Development Bank Group: News and Events*. Retrieved from Liberia: African Development Fund grant to modernise payments infrastructure and systems: https://www.afdb.org/en/news-and-events/press-releases/liberia-african-development-fund-grant-modernise-payments-infrastructure-and-systems-59903

AIC Progetti SpA. (2018). *Design and priority sections of the coastal highway in Liberia. Environmental and social impact assessment (ESIA) report.* Retrieved from https://esa.afdb.org/sites/default/files/Coastal%20High%20Way%20Project%20-%20Part%206%20ESIA%20Report%20March2018.pdf

Bertelsmann Stiftung. (2022). *BTI 2022 Country Report — Liberia.* Gütersloh: Bertelsmann Stiftung. Retrieved from https://bti-project.org/fileadmin/api/content/en/downloads/reports/country_report_2022_LBR.pdf

Britannica. (2023). *History of Liberia*. Retrieved from Britannica Encyclopedia: https://www.britannica.com/place/Liberia/History

Ceigram. (2018). *Liberia - Agricultural risk assessment study.* Retrieved from https://www.p4arm.org/app/uploads/2019/04/Liberia_Agricultural-risk-assesment-study.pdf

Center for Justice and Accountability, CJA. (2022, April 10). *LIBERIA*. Retrieved from https://cja.org/where-we-work/liberia/

Deleanu, A. (2014). The Oda Dimension Of China: The Case Of Africa. *SEA - Practical Application of Science, 2*(3).

Department of State. United States of America. (2023). *Founding of Liberia, 1847*. Retrieved from Office of the Historian: https://history.state.gov/milestones/1830-1860/liberia

Embassy of the People's Republic of China in the Republic of Liberia. (2021). *The outcome of China-Liberia cooperation is widely recognised*. Retrieved from http://lr.china-embassy.gov.cn/eng/sghdhzxxx/202111/t20211117_10449434.htm#:~:text=The%20Chinese%20enterprises'%20investment%20in,promoting%20economic%20development%20in%20Liberia.

European Commission. (n.d.). *International Partnerships - Liberia*. Retrieved from https://international-partnerships.ec.europa.eu/countries/liberia_en

Fund for Peace. (2023). *Measuring fragility - Risk and vulnerability in 179 countries*. Retrieved from Fragile States Index: https://fragilestatesindex.org/

GoL. (n.d.). *Liberia national forest inventory 2018/2019.* Retrieved from https://www.forestcarbonpartnership.org/system/files/documents/Liberia%20National%20Forest%20Inventory.pdf

Gunn A., D. J. (2018). A review of the mineral potential of Liberia. *Ore Geology Reviews, 101*, 413-431. Retrieved from https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0169136818300994

IMF. (2021). *Liberia - Poverty Reduction and Growth Strategy.* Retrieved from https://www.elibrary.imf.org/view/journals/002/2021/010/article-A001-en.xml

International Trade Administration. (2022). *Liberia - Country Commercial Guide*. Retrieved from https://www.trade.gov/country-commercial-guides/liberia-trade-agreements

Liberia's Ministry of Planning and Economic Affairs. (2012). *Agenda for transformation: Steps toward Liberia RISING 2030.* Retrieved from https://www.ilo.org/dyn/youthpol/es/equest.fileutils.dochandle?p_uploaded_file_id=81

Library of Congress. (2022). *Liberia: Law Authorizing Dual Citizenship and Allowing Women to Pass Citizenship to Their Children Enacted*. Retrieved from https://www.loc.gov/item/global-legal-monitor/2022-10-12/liberia-law-authorizing-dual-citizenship-and-allowing-women-to-pass-citizenship-to-their-children-enacted/

MO Ibrahim Foundation. (2022). *2022 Ibrahim Index of African Governance.*

Nations encyclopedia. (n.d.). *Liberia - Services*. Retrieved from https://www.nationsencyclopedia.com/economies/Africa/Liberia-SERVICES.html

Naymote. (2022). *Four years performance report of President George Manneh Weah in office.* Retrieved from https://naymote.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/01/The-President-Meter-Project-2022-04.pdf

Naymote. (n.d.). *The President Meter Project*. Retrieved from https://naymote.com/asset-management/

Norwegian Refugee Council. (2003). *Profile of internal displacement: Liberia.* Retrieved from http://archive.niza.nl/docs/200310271243117485.pdf

OEC. (2023). *Economic Complexity Index*. Retrieved from https://oec.world/en/visualize/tree_map/hs92/import/lbr/show/all/2020/

OECD. (2008). *African Economic Outlook.* AfDB/OECD.

Pillai, B. (2022). *Liberia: The Young Girl's Time Is Now — Their Rights, Their Future*. Retrieved from Daily Observer: https://www.liberianobserver.com/liberia-young-girls-time-now-their-rights-their-future#:~:text=According%20to%20the%20Ministry%20of,several%20factors%2C%20including%20early%20pregnancy.

ReliefWeb. (2016). *Climate Change Vulnerability Index 2017.* Retrieved from https://reliefweb.int/report/world/climate-change-vulnerability-index-2017

Republic of Liberia. (2018). *Pro-poor agenda for prosperity and development (PAPD).*

Takagi, S., Donovan, D., Kayizzi-Mugerwa, S., & Perez, L. (2018). *The IMF and Fragile States: eight African Country Cases.* Retrieved from https://ieo.imf.org/en/our-work/Evaluations/Completed/2018-0403-the-imf-and-fragile-states

Transparency International. (2023). *Corruption Perceptions Index 2022.* Transparency International.

UNDP. (2022). *Human development report 2021/2022.* Retrieved from https://www.undp.org/liberia/press-releases/multiple-global-crises-reverse-human-development-gains-worldwide-undp-report-finds

UNHCR. (2012). *Struggling to find solutions: Liberian refugees in Ghana.* Retrieved from https://www.unhcr.org/4fbb7f075.pdf

UNHCR. (2013). *UNHCR completes repatriation of 155,000 Liberians*. Retrieved from https://www.unhcr.org/news/makingdifference/2013/1/50e6af089/unhcr-completes-repatriation-155000-liberians.html

United Nations. (2007). *Security Council lifts ban on diamond exports from Liberia*. Retrieved from UN News: https://news.un.org/en/story/2007/04/217102#:~:text=The%20Security%20Council%20voted%20today,fuelling%20wars%20across%20West%20Africa.

United Nations. (2018). *Africa Renewal*. Retrieved from Mission accomplished: 15 years of peacekeeping success in Liberia.: https://www.un.org/africarenewal/magazine/april-2018-july-2018/mission-accomplished-15-years-peacekeeping-success-liberia

US Department of State. (2019). *US relations with Liberia*. Retrieved from https://www.state.gov/u-s-relations-with-liberia/

USAID. (2016). *Liberian businesses: the Engines of economic recovery and growth - A market overview report.* Retrieved from https://buildingmarkets.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/08/liberian_businesses_-_the_engines_of_economic_recovery_and_growth.pdf

USAID GlobalWaters. (2023, June 29). *LIBERIA. Overview.* Retrieved from https://www.globalwaters.org/wherewework/africa/liberia#:~:text=As%20a%20result%2C%20only%2070,17%20percent%20to%20basic%20sanitation.

World Bank. (2021). *Liberia Human Capital Assessment: from constraints to opportunities.* Retrieved from https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/330421637359900075/pdf/Liberia-Human-Capital-Assessment-from-Constraints-to-Opportunities.pdf

World Bank. (2023, June). *The World Bank Data*. Retrieved from Liberia Development Indicators: https://data.worldbank.org/country/liberia

World Bank. (2023, June). *World Bank News*. Retrieved from Liberia Economic Update: Prospects for Inclusive and Sustainable Growth: https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/press-release/2022/09/27/liberia-economic-update-prospects-for-inclusive-and-sustainable-growth

World Bank. (2023a). *The World Bank in Liberia*. Retrieved from https://www.worldbank.org/en/country/liberia/overview

World Bank. (2023b). *World Bank Open Data*. Retrieved from https://data.worldbank.org/

World Bank. (2023c). *Rural Access Index (RAI)*. Retrieved from https://datacatalog.worldbank.org/search/dataset/0038250

World Bank. (2023d). *Poverty and equity brief - Liberia.* Retrieved from https://databankfiles.worldbank.org/public/ddpext_download/poverty/987B9C90-CB9F-4D93-AE8C-750588BF00QA/current/Global_POVEQ_LBR.pdf

World Bank Group. (2018). *From growth to development: Priorities for sustainably reudcing poverty and achieving middle-income status by 2030.* Retrieved from https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/585371528125859387/pdf/Liberia-From-growth-to-development-priorities-for-sustainably-reducing-poverty-and-achieving-middle-income-status-by-2030.pdf

Worzi, A. (2022). *Liberia: "Early Warning Signs of Violence ahead of 2023 Elections"*. Retrieved from The Observer: https://www.liberianobserver.com/liberia-early-warning-signs-violence-ahead-2023-elections